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Death in the time of Durga Puja

North Kolkata pandal stampede exposes gaps in safety arrangements

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SECOND T20I

India looks to sustain the momentum

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INSIDE



AI to be used to verify attendance in jobs scheme

NEW DELHI
To plug the gaps that allegedly allowed misuse of the mobile application used to capture workers' attendance under the rural employment programme, Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission Gramin (VB-G RAM G), Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday said an upgraded version with AI-based verification and other features, will be used. » PAGE 4

'Net FDI $3.3 bn in Aug., positive for 3rd month'

NEW DELHI
Net foreign direct investment (FDI) was positive for the third consecutive month in August with inflows exceeding outflows by $3.3 billion, as per latest data from the Reserve Bank of India. » PAGE 11

'Congress ticket aspirant behind sting operation'

BENGALURU/MYSURU
The alleged sting operation targeting former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah took a fresh turn on Friday, with his son and Urban Development Minister Yathindra Siddaramaiah alleging that a Congress woman leader was behind the episode. » PAGE 2

Israel plans to hit West Bank after death of soldiers

HEBRON
Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu threatened a military operation in the occupied West Bank on a scale unseen in decades after Palestinian gunmen killed two Israeli soldiers on Friday in an attack days before national elections. » PAGE 12



Andhra Pradesh and Odisha gear up for cyclone

BHUBANESWAR
The weather system over the Bay of Bengal is likely to intensify into a cyclone and cross the southern Odisha-northern Andhra Pradesh coast by October 28. The landfall point remains uncertain. The IMD has forecast heavy to very heavy rainfall in Odisha from October 26 and in Andhra Pradesh from October 27. » PAGE 5

LAC 'disturbed' by PLA's behaviour, admits MEA

- India, China in touch about understanding of LAC for better border management: Ministry
- Response comes after ITBP chief's remarks on 'face-offs' in Arunachal Pradesh since this July
- Video of Shatrujeet Kapur's remarks in Alwar removed from ITBP's official YouTube channel

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

The Line of Actual Control (LAC) has been "disturbed" by the People's Liberation Army's (PLA) patrolling behaviour, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday in response to questions about a report in *The Hindu* on skirmishes along the LAC in Arunachal Pradesh.

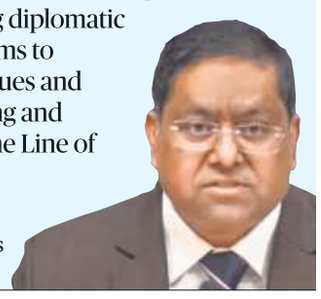
The report, which had quoted the outgoing Director-General of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police Force (ITBP), Shatrujeet Kapur, expressing concern over "face-offs" under way since July, led to the Congress criticising the Centre.

Despite the Ministry's confirmation, the video of Mr. Kapur's speech, given at an event in Alwar on Thursday, was deleted from the ITBP's official YouTube channel.

This was the first time the government has officially accepted that, more than two years after Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping announced a détente between their militaries, the border areas remain tense and "get disturbed" over patrolling routes.

"As we have noted in the past, the situation in the India-China border areas gets disturbed from time to time when Chinese forces diverge from established patrolling patterns," Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal told journalists at a briefing here, blaming the PLA for the divergences.

> Both sides [India and China] continue to use existing diplomatic and military mechanisms to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation along the Line of Actual Control
>
> **RANDHIR JAISWAL**
> Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson



"Both sides continue to use existing diplomatic and military mechanisms to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation along the Line of Actual Control," he added, directing queries on the specific situation to the Ministry of Defence.

Mr. Jaiswal also reiterated the government's position since the beginning of the four-year military stand-off at the LAC, including the Galwan clashes in 2020, that the "maintenance of peace and tranquility in the border areas is essential for the overall development of bilateral relations", and said that both sides were in touch about improving their understanding of the LAC for "better border management".

The government's response came after the Opposition demanded a clarification on the situation in Arunachal Pradesh.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge asked Prime Minister Modi to explain the "continuing face-offs" between Indian and Chinese troops at several locations along the Arunachal Pradesh border, questioning whether India's patrolling access had been compromised and whether the pre-May 2020 status quo had been restored.

In a post on X, Mr. Kharge said the confirmation by the chief of ITBP force stationed at the LAC was "deeply alarming".

The Congress chief alleged that Mr. Modi's June 2020 statement that no one had entered Indian territory after the Galwan clashes had emboldened China.

'Govt. suppressing info'

Addressing a press conference, Congress media and publicity department chairman, Pawan Khera, commended the ITBP's "Shaurya Commandos" for handling the confrontations with China, but accused the government of suppressing information from the border.

"The fact that China has entered our territory does not bother [the government]; what bothers them is that this has been reported," Mr. Khera said, adding that "image is more important for them than the country's interests".

The Congress questioned the government's easing of restrictions on Chinese investment and the growing trade deficit.

"India's trade deficit with China zoomed even further to a record $112 billion in 2025-26, up from $99 billion the previous year. This has simply crushed our MSMEs in many industries," Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said in a post, adding, "Make in India has become Import from China. This staggering trade deficit is in itself a very significant threat to our economic security."

Winter blues



Temporary measures: Mist is sprayed on a road in New Delhi using pole-mounted spraying systems to curb pollution. The city's air quality shows no improvement despite years of emergency measures, with the average AQI worsening over the past four years. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Students, farmers, and civil society groups step up stir against SIR, CEC in capital

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI



Security personnel detain protesters demanding CEC Gyanesh Kumar's resignation, in New Delhi on Friday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Around 500 protesters from students, youth, women, farmers, and civil society organisations, under the banner of 'People Against SIR', marched through Central Delhi on Friday, demanding the rollback of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. The march was part of a series of protests held across the country against the exercise.

The Delhi Police said around 20 protesters were detained and later released, even as protesters claimed that around 50 were rounded up. Police registered at least one FIR against protesters for violating prohibitory orders under Section 163 of Bharatiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

The protesters, carrying the national flag, banners, and placards, assembled near the Gol Dak Khana roundabout at the intersection of Kali Bari Marg and Bhai Vir Singh Marg, before attempting to march towards the Election Commission of India (ECI) headquarters. Ahead of the 1 p.m. protest call, participants gathered in small groups around Bangla Sahib Gurdwara.

Mixed pod

Political activist Yogendra Yadav, Communist Party of India leader Annie Raja, and All India Kisan Sabha vice-president Inderjeet Singh joined the march.

Representatives of student organisations, including the All India Students' Association, All India Students' Federation, Students' Federation of India, Krantikari Yuva Sangathan and All India Democratic Students' Organisation, also participated.

Addressing protesters, Mr. Yadav said the movement would continue despite restrictions on demonstrations, including the denotification of Jantar Mantar as a protest site.

"The protest will continue. If you shut down one Jantar Mantar, hundreds more will emerge. If you try to silence one person, people will not remain quiet. People and organisations may change, but the movement will go on. Until Gyanesh Kumar resigns, we will continue to protest," he said.

Mr. Singh said the Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM) decided to support the movement after the protesters, particularly women, were manhandled during earlier demonstrations in Delhi. "...Enough is enough. We will continue to support this movement until the SIR is scrapped, the right to vote is protected, and the right to protest at Jantar Mantar is restored," he said.

Mr. Singh also opposed giving police power via Special Executive Magistrates in proceedings against protesters, arguing the arrangement concentrated too much authority in the hands of the police.

Annie Raja accused the Centre of using the SIR exercise to undermine constitutional safeguards.

'Protests to continue'

"The SIR is a tool being used by the Narendra Modi government to undermine the Constitution. The people of this country will not allow that to happen, which is why we continue to raise our voices. We have come very close to the CEC's office today. Soon we will also reach there and ask him to get out," she said.

"From Kashmir to Kanyakumari, and from the Northeast to Gujarat, people are organising their own Jantar Mantars. Even if the authorities restrict one protest site, people will find ways to make their voices heard," she said.

The protesters began marching towards the ECI office but were stopped by barricades and security personnel on Ashoka Road, around 500 metres into the march. They briefly sat down on the road as the police warned them about prohibitory orders.

The police subsequently pushed the protesters back towards the main road, using whistles and repeated warnings about detention for violating the restrictions. As slogans continued, several protesters were taken away in two detention vehicles.

Gunmen kill seven at Jordan church, king vows retaliation for 'rare attack'

Agence France-Presse
AMMAN



People and security forces outside Greek Orthodox Church in the village of Hammoud in Jordan's Karak governorate on Friday. AFP

Gunmen killed at least seven people and wounded dozens at a church in southern Jordan on Friday, authorities said, with the king vowing retaliation for the rare attack on Christians in the majority Sunni Muslim kingdom.

Assailants stormed the compound of a Greek Orthodox church in the village of Hammoud in Karak governorate and opened fire, authorities said.

The gunmen got out of a vehicle and started shooting during a funeral procession, the public security directorate said in a statement, adding that a manhunt was under way for the perpetrators.

"The terrorist attack against Karak will be met with the harshest retaliation," Abdullah II said in an English-language post on X. "We will strike with an iron fist against those who dare to threaten our nation."

According to images from state broadcaster Al-Mamlaka, the king arrived in Karak on Friday evening.

After authorities gave a death toll of six, Director of Public Security Major General Abdullah Al-Maaytah said it had risen to seven with 34 injured, 27 of whom were still receiving treatment.

"A terrorist group has carried out a horrific act, one that is condemned in every respect, and the security services are working round the clock to track them down," Interior Minister Mazen Al-Faraya told a press conference.

Minister of Government Communications Mohammed Al-Momani said security forces were investigating the attack.

A witness told Al-Mamlaka the gunmen fired continuously for five minutes before fleeing the scene. Between 150 and 200 people were in and around the church at the time, the witness said.

Karak is home to a significant Christian community in the Muslim-majority kingdom, where Christians make up between two and three per cent of the population.

The Greek Orthodox Archdiocese in Jordan said that if the attack was aimed at driving out Christians from the holy land, "it will only make us cling to it more firmly and deepen our roots in it".

"We are absolutely certain that Jordanian society will remain impervious to every dark, extremist ideology," it added.



Om Prakash Mathur

Om Prakash Mathur sworn in as Keralam Governor

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The 29th Governor of Keralam, Om Prakash Mathur, was sworn in on Friday at a ceremony held at Lok Bhavan here which was attended by Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan, Speaker Thiruvanchoor Radhakrishnan, Ministers, elected representatives, and Leaders from various political parties. Mr. Mathur succeeds Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, who has been appointed as the Governor of Tamil Nadu.

Kerala High Court Chief Justice Soumen Sen administered the oath of office to Mr. Mathur. Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan was absent from the event.

Prior to his present appointment, Mr. Mathur was serving as the Governor of Sikkim. Hailing from Rajasthan's Pali district, Mr. Mathur entered public life as a Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh pracharak and later became a national general secretary of the Bharatiya Janata Party. He also served as a Rajya Sabha member before taking up gubernatorial duties.

Cong. ticket aspirant behind sting operation: Yathindra

Siddaramaiah alleges that Cong. leader Krupa Alva and media representative Rakesh Shetty are involved in the episode; he calls for investigation; KPCC likely to issue show-cause notice to Alva

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU/MYSURU

The alleged sting operation targeting former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah took a fresh turn on Friday, with his son and Urban Development Minister Yathindra Siddaramaiah alleging that a Congress woman leader was behind the episode.

Speaking to reporters, Mr. Yathindra said the woman leader was keen on securing Congress ticket to contest in the Puttur Assembly constituency in Dakshina Kannada district. He alleged that she had joined hands with the head of a media organisation to carry out the operation.



Congress leader Siddaramaiah and his son Yathindra. FILE PHOTO

Mr. Siddaramaiah later identified the woman as Krupa Alva and the media representative as Rakesh Shetty, owner of Power TV.

Mr. Yathindra said an investigation was necessary to establish whether the Congress leader and the media representative had acted on their own or whether others were behind the episode.

Breaking his long silence, the former Chief Minister spoke later in Mysuru, and called for a fair investigation, alleging that the whole episode was aimed at "blackmailing" him. Mr. Siddaramaiah said he had lodged a police complaint against what he termed "a false case".

Soon after, KPCC president B.K. Hariprasad said a show-cause notice would be issued to Ms. Alva, who is a KPCC spokesperson, seeking an explanation for her alleged role in the episode.

Congress sources said the party was considering expelling her for allegedly embarrassing the government and giving the Opposition ammunition to target it.

Mr. Shetty, head of the TV channel, has obtained interim anticipatory bail in connection with the sting operation case being investigated by the Central Crime Branch of the Bengaluru police.

Candidates still being 'obstructed': YSRCP

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) president Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy on Friday said his party would approach the Supreme Court again with "fresh evidence," alleging that its candidates in the local body polls were still being obstructed through "intimidation, attacks, rejection of nominations and forged withdrawal letters."

He alleged that Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, the police and the State Election Commission (SEC) were in concert to prevent the YSRCP candidates from filing nominations.

Stating that unauthorised candidates had filed nominations using the YSRCP name, he said the party would submit the candidates' list and supporting evidence to the SEC and the courts.

HC to hear Pinarayi's petition on Monday

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court is set to hear Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan's appeal challenging a Single Bench order in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case on Monday.

The Single Bench had directed the registration of a first information report (FIR) against Mr. Vijayan, daughter T. Veena and son-in-law and former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas in the case. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) had passed on information on their finding of a predicate offence allegedly committed by Mr. Vijayan and kin, while investigating the pay-off case, to the State Police Chief.

A Division Bench denied Mr. Vijayan permission to appeal the Single Bench order, prompting him to seek a stay from the Supreme Court.

TVK, DMK walk out of meeting on SSR of electoral rolls in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Nine of the 12 recognised national and State political parties that attended a meeting convened by Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik at the Secretariat in Chennai on Friday to discuss the coming special summary revision (SSR) of the electoral rolls walked out after recording their views and demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

The ruling TVK and its allies and the DMK, the principal Opposition party, were among those that staged the walkout.

The Election Commission of India (ECI) had invited six recognised national parties – the Congress, the BJP, the BSP, the AAP, the CPI(M), and the NPP – and seven recognised State parties – the TVK, the DMK, the AIADMK, the CPI, the NTK, the VCK, and the DMDK – to the meeting.

Barring the BSP, the other parties took part in the meeting.

Representatives of the BJP, the AIADMK, and the NPP were among those who did not stage a walkout, while the others walked out at various stages of the meeting, with some recording their views before leaving.

Minister for Energy Resources and Law C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar, who attended the meeting on behalf of the TVK, told reporters after the walkout that the SSR was unnecessary



TVK leader and Minister C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar walking out of the meeting by the CEO in Chennai on Friday. R. RAGU

when the errors in the special intensive revision (SIR) had not yet been rectified. He alleged that a large number of voters had been deleted from the rolls during the SIR.

The Minister also demanded the resignation of the Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar.

Concern of the people

Former DMK MLA I. Paranthaman said the party had conveyed its views, highlighting the concern of the people, before staging the walkout. He said the SIR was marked by several irregularities, which the DMK had repeatedly flagged even before the election.

As many as 74 lakh voters had been deleted from the rolls, Mr. Paranthaman said, asking what steps the ECI had taken to enrol the eligible voters. "The ECI should be people-friendly and facilitate the enrolment of eligible voters. While campaigning for 100% voter turnout, the Commission is, however, creating obstacles to the inclusion of eligible electors in the rolls," he alleged.

LDF demands restoration of all names deleted in SIR

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Representatives of the Left Democratic Front (LDF) walked out of an all-party meeting convened by Chief Electoral Officer D. Sajith Babu on Friday, demanding the reinstatement of all voters excluded from the electoral roll after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Keralam.

Senior Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI (M)] leader M.V. Jayarajan and Communist Party of India (CPI) leader Sathyan Mokeri later said they demanded that election officials restore the names of 24.08 lakh voters excluded when the draft SIR list was published.

"The CEO expressed his helplessness. We have asked the CEO to convey the demand to the Election Commission of India (ECI)," Mr. Jayarajan said.

The meeting was convened in connection with the Special Summary Revision (SSR) of the electoral roll currently under way in the State. Political parties demanded an extension of the November 2 deadline for rationalising polling stations in Keralam. Mr. Sajith Babu said he had informed the leaders that he would convey their demand to the ECI.

While political parties claim that 24.08 lakh voters were excluded after the Keralam round of SIR, election officials say this was the number in the draft list. The number fell to 8.97 lakh in the final SIR list.

INBRIEF



Local body polls will not be held in 69 Amaravati villages

Amid the elaborate preparations and hectic political activities across Andhra Pradesh in the run-up to the local body elections, 69 villages falling within the Amaravati region will have to wait for some more years to participate in the polls as the government is working on a separate governance framework for the mega capital city. Located in Tadikonda, Pedakurapadu, Guntur East and Guntur West Assembly constituencies, the villages fall within the limits of the proposed Amaravati Outer Ring Road.

Passengers stranded amid flight delays in Bengaluru

Multiple SpiceJet flights departing from Kempegowda International Airport in Bengaluru were delayed on Wednesday and Thursday, leaving passengers waiting for several hours beyond their scheduled departure time. Three domestic services connecting Bengaluru with Kolkata and Mumbai were affected, with delays extending into the early hours of the following day. The disruptions involved two Kolkata-bound flights and one Mumbai-bound service. The airline has not specified the operational or technical issues, if any, that led to the delays.

Case filed over 'defamatory' remarks against Rahul

The Kerala Police have registered cases in Kannur over alleged defamatory remarks about Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, social media posts targeting Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan, and a fabricated Facebook post allegedly defaming Kannur MLA T.O. Mohanan. The police have registered a case against BJP leader K. Sreekanth following a complaint over remarks made at a public meeting that allegedly defamed Mr. Gandhi. The allegations in the cases are yet to be established.

Tribute to a valiant queen



Celebrating a legacy: Folk artistes perform during a procession welcoming Veera Jyoti in Kakati, the village of freedom fighter Rani Channamma, near Belagavi in Karnataka on Friday. Veera Jyoti refers to the ceremonial torch or flame carried during the Kittur Utsav to commemorate the historic victory of Rani Channamma over the British East India Company. P.K. BADIGER

Revanth calls for a unified police force across south India

Naveen Kumar
HYDERABAD

No State can become crime-free through its efforts alone, said Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Friday, calling for a coordinated policing network across southern India to tackle criminal activities that increasingly extend beyond geographical boundaries.

Inaugurating the Southern States' Police Coordination Committee meeting in Hyderabad, the Chief Minister offered to share Telangana's technological infrastructure and command centre framework with neighbouring States to strengthen intelligence-sharing and law enforcement.

The conference brought together Directors General of Police and senior officers from Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Kerala, besides representatives from the Union Territories of Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Puducherry and Lakshadweep, and central security and investigating agencies.

Mr. Reddy urged the participating police chiefs to formulate a comprehensive action plan to address emerging challenges, including cybercrime and narcotics trafficking.

Karnataka CM seeks Poland's partnership for investors' meet

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Welcoming Poland Prime Minister Donald Tusk and his delegation to Bengaluru, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Friday invited the European nation to participate as a partner in the State's Global Investors Meet 2027.

In a meeting with Mr. Tusk here, Mr. Shivakumar said, "Karnataka is keen to deepen bilateral co-operation in investment, technology, innovation, and employment, building on Bengaluru's technology ecosystem and Poland's expertise in advanced manufacturing." Reciprocating the interest, Mr. Tusk said India and Poland should move beyond traditional trade and deepen cooperation in technology, AI, and aerospace, to strengthen their economies.

Mr. Shivakumar welcomed the proposed investment by Poland's TZMO Group of approximately ₹80 crore in the KIADB Vemgal Industrial Area in Kolar district. The project has the potential to generate around 1,000 jobs and introduce the manufacture of smart adult incontinence pads in India for the first time.

(With inputs from PTI)

Revanth asks officials to gear up for talks with Maharashtra over construction of barrage

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Friday asked officials to be prepared for talks with Maharashtra soon by building a case to convince the upper riparian State on the construction of Tummidihatti Barrage across Pranahitha river with full reservoir level (FRL) of 152 metres.

In a meeting with Ministers and officials here, Mr. Reddy noted that his Maharashtra counterpart Devendra Fadnavis had indicated recently that Telangana would be called for discussion on the barrage after Friday.



A. Revanth Reddy

Engineers explained to the Chief Minister the details about possible quantities of water diversion/lifting to Yellampally project with the Tummidihatti Barrage's FRL at 152 metres and 150 metres.

They stated that no villages would submerge in Maharashtra with the construction of the barrage and only 2,300 acres would face submergence with 152 metres FRL and less than 1,000 acres with 150 metres FRL.

Mr. Reddy told the officials to share all necessary information sought by the Central Water Commission (CWC) following a meeting between the two States held in New Delhi last month.

Kerala HC refuses to stay reconstitution of Waqf board

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

A Division Bench of the Kerala High Court has refused to stay the reconstitution of the Kerala State Waqf Board. The court was considering appeals by former board chairperson K.S. Hamza and member C.K. Usman Haji against a single Bench order, which had refused to stay the reconstitution as well.

The court held that a stay could not be granted, as the new board had taken charge. The State had reconstituted the board on October 16 and nominated nine new members.

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NIA case: Delhi court allows accused to extend stay abroad

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A U.S. citizen and six Ukrainian nationals have been accused of training armed groups in Myanmar

A Delhi court on Friday allowed a U.S. citizen and six Ukrainian nationals linked to the Myanmar arms training case to stay outside India until February 24, 2027. The seven accused were arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) earlier this year.

Special Judge Prashant Sharma of the Patiala House Court passed the order after considering applications filed by the seven accused seeking an extension of their overseas stay. The proceedings were held in camera.

The U.S. national, Matthew Aaron VanDyke, was arrested by the NIA at Kolkata airport on March 13. The six Ukrainians – Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskyi, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim and Kaminskyi Viktor – were arrested at airports in Delhi and Lucknow.

The accused entered India on tourist visas and travelled to the northeastern region without obtaining mandatory permits.

Investigators alleged that they subsequently crossed from Mizoram into Myanmar, where they trained ethnic armed organisations.

The NIA initially invoked provisions of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act , including those concerning conspiracy. The agency also claimed that the accused made disclosures during questioning about an alleged cross-border network and were involved in assembling equipment linked to an alleged plot targeting a passenger aircraft in Myanmar. However, the agency did not include the UAPA provisions in its initial chargesheet.

Govt. to revise labour survey to track gig, household work

Periodic Labour Force Survey to identify households with at least one digital platform worker; it will also have questions to capture engagement in caregiving activities and unpaid trainee work

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Hidden labour: The revised labour survey aims to better capture the economic contribution of women's unpaid work. IMRAN NISSAR

The Union government has decided to change the design and structure of the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) to track digital platform workers and capture engagement in unpaid household, caregiving, volunteer, and trainee work. The PLFS will also include additional questions to measure labour underutilisation.

According to a press release and concept note issued here on Friday, the National Sample Survey Office (NSSO), under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), has proposed modifications to the PLFS sampling design starting January 2027. The survey schedule will also change.

The Ministry has invited comments and suggestions from policymakers, researchers, academic institutions, and the public within 15 days from Friday.

A separate Second Stage Stratum (SSS) will be introduced in the PLFS to identify households with at least one digital platform worker. An additional entry will be added to the questionnaire to determine whether any member of the household has engaged in digital platform work during the specified reference period. "There will be four SSSs in rural areas and five in urban areas, with 14 households canvassed in each selected First Stage Unit (FSU). This revision in SSS formation is expected to improve the coverage of digital platform workers and facilitate more comprehensive data collection on this emerging segment of the labour market," the press release said.

Concept note

According to the concept note, a large proportion of women in India spend considerable time on unpaid household and caregiving activities, such as cooking, cleaning, childcare, and caring for elderly, sick, or disabled family members.

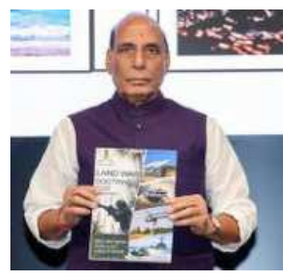
"While such activities contribute significantly to household well-being and facilitate the participation of other household members in paid employment, they have not been measured separately in PLFS until now," it noted, adding that specific questions will be incorporated to capture engagement in own-use production of goods, and unpaid household and caregiving activities.

Additionally, the criteria for sample allocation and stratification have been updated.

"These revisions are expected to improve the efficiency of sample allocation and ensure better representation of population variations, which in turn will minimise operational difficulties during sample selection," the release said.

Army needs flexibility with long-term vision, says Defence Minister

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI



Rajnath Singh

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday called on the Army's senior leadership to develop a long-term strategic vision for the next 20-30 years while remaining prepared to respond to immediate and emerging security challenges amid a changing geopolitical and regional environment.

Addressing the Army Commanders' Conference in New Delhi, Mr. Singh stressed the need for dynamic and flexible strategies that can be adjusted to evolving circumstances. He released the *Land Warfare Doctrine*, which provides an overarching framework for preparing the Army to address the evolving character of warfare and future conflicts.

Mr. Singh also called for an integrated approach to modern warfare, emphasising that land operations and ground forces would remain indispensable despite the growing significance of air, maritime, space, and cyber domains.

Commending the armed forces for adapting to changing operational requirements, the Defence Minister said innovative thinking, enhanced synergy, improved coordination, and advanced weaponry had contributed to the success of Operation Sindoor. The operation had sent a clear message that India would not hesitate to take necessary measures to safeguard its national interests, he said. He credited the armed forces' valour, discipline, preparedness, and restraint, along with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's diplomatic efforts for strengthening India's global standing.

Audio clip on '₹500-crore' payment to activist will be probed: Maharashtra CM

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI



Devendra Fadnavis

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday broke his silence over Maratha activist Manoj Jarange Patil recently releasing an audio clip which claimed that Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde allegedly took ₹500 crore from the Bharatiya Janata Party to hand it over to him to stop his agitation. Mr. Patil said that he had neither received the money nor would he stop the agitation.

The Chief Minister said that the purported audio clip will be sent for forensic examination and that the truth will be brought out. The Opposition hit out at the government seeking a thorough probe in the matter. Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut challenged Union Minister Amit Shah and the Central agencies to investigate the claim. Mr. Shinde has already denied the allegations while his party's delegation has also met the Chief Minister to seek a probe in the matter.

"We are all wondering why this clip has been leaked after 2.5 years. What is the purpose behind it? There is a demand for a thorough probe not just by Jarange Patil, but also by the Shiv Sena, but also by the BJP. We will bring out the truth in the matter," Mr. Fadnavis said.

Sources in the BJP have admitted that the 2.5-year old clip has damaged its image among the Maratha community and has upset its alliance partners. "There were some squabbles which already existed. This has only added to them. It is damaging for the alliance. Not just that, it is damaging for the party too. It has distanced us further from the Maratha community. But it will not lead to anything. We have strong numbers," a senior BJP leader said on condition of anonymity.

Elections for 8 MLC seats in Bihar pass off peacefully

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Elections for eight Bihar Legislative Council seats, four each from the Graduates' and Teachers' constituencies, passed off peacefully on Friday, even as the Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) accused the police in Patna of having "misused" their power to harass its candidate.

The results will be announced on October 27. The turnout in the elections was 43.87% for the four Graduates' seats and 74.55% for the Teachers' constituencies. Tejashwi Yadav of RJD and the party's candidate from the Patna Teachers' constituency, Sanjeev Kumar Singh, alleged that the police "harassed the candidate to influence the poll."

SP alleges bogus voting by BJP as elections conclude for 11 Council seats in U.P.

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW



Five graduates' constituencies and six teacher's constituencies went to the polls. ANI

Elections for 11 Legislative Council seats concluded on Friday in Uttar Pradesh amid allegations by the Opposition of bogus voting by Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) supporters.

The BJP dismissed the allegations, calling them an acceptance of defeat before the results are announced.

The Samajwadi Party (SP) has raised the issue with the Election Commission (ECI) and demanded action. "BJP members are disappointed and frustrated. The teacher and graduate constituency election is for a limited number of voters, with only teachers and graduates participating. The BJP supporters attempted fraudulent voting. To prevent SP supporters from voting, the BJP deployed its goons and corrupt officials," said SP president Akhilesh Yadav, who cast his vote in Saifai under the Agra Graduate constituency.

Five graduates' constituencies (Lucknow, Agra, Meerut, Varanasi, and Allahabad-Jhansi) and six teachers' constituencies (Lucknow, Agra, Meerut, Varanasi, Bareilly-Moradabad, and Gorakhpur-Faizabad) covering over 30 districts in the State went to the polls. These constituencies had over 14 lakh registered voters.

Total voter turnout stood at 55.24% until 4 p.m., according to Election Commission figures.

In Auraiya district, the SP alleged its workers were beaten.

Similarly, the party alleged fake voting took place by people associated with the BJP at booth number 34 at Maharaj Singh Degree College in the Saharanpur City Assembly segment.

At least four dead in blast in Bihar's Siwan district

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

At least four people were killed in a massive blast at a house where firecrackers were being made in Bihar's Siwan district on Friday.

The area has been cordoned off for security reasons, Siwan Superintendet of Police Bharat Soni said, adding that the toll could increase.

Rescue operations led by town Sub-Divisional Officer (SDO) Ashutosh Kumar Gupta are under way, while top police officials reached the blast site.

According to people in the neighbourhood, the blast occurred at the residence of Mohd. Amaruddin Mian, at whose house manufacturing of firecrackers has been going on for several years.

Navy to host Indo-Pacific meet from November 3

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Indian Navy will host the 2026 edition of the Indo-Pacific Regional Dialogue in New Delhi from November 3 to 5, bringing together maritime practitioners, scientists, academicians, policymakers, and experts from 18 countries to explore cooperation in science, technology, and research, a Defence Ministry release said on Friday.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh is scheduled to deliver the commemorative address on the opening day of the event which will focus on the theme "Science, Technology, and Academic Cooperation in the Indo-Pacific".

The discussions at the Navy's principal strategic outreach initiative will seek to identify practical measures to strengthen regional cooperation in maritime research, ocean governance, climate resilience, and emerging technologies, against the backdrop of growing maritime vulnerabilities.

Jaishankar visits Azerbaijan to ease strain in ties over Operation Sindoor

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI



External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar meets Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev in Baku on Friday. AFP

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Friday met Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev in Baku and said the visit charted a "pathway" for the future of bilateral ties. The meeting comes more than a year after relations between India and Azerbaijan deteriorated over the latter's opposition to India's Operation Sindoor against Pakistan.

Mr. Jaishankar also met his counterpart Jayhun Bayramov, who said the two countries had "different view points on different issues" earlier, but highlighted new areas of cooperation such as energy, and tourism after what he described as a "fruitful discussion".

"We have common interest in really promoting peace and progress and prosperity. And threats like terrorism, conflict, and instability are our common enemies," Mr. Jaishankar said in his remarks to the media after the meeting with Mr. Bayramov.

"Delighted to welcome the External Affairs Minister of India, Dr. S. Jaishankar, to exchange views on the current state and prospects of Azerbaijan-India relations, including political dialogue, trade and investment, energy, tourism and cultural ties," said Mr. Bayramov, emphasising "continued dialogue and exploration of opportunities for cooperation in areas of mutual interest".

Way forward

"Our talks charted a pathway forward for our relationship. Agreed to deepen political consultations, exchange visits, enhance economic activities, build connectivity and foster people-to-people ties," Mr. Jaishankar said. He also extended India's support to the peace process between Azerbaijan and Armenia.

The statement is the first major conciliatory step from the Indian side since Azerbaijan had expressed concern over the India-initiated Operation Sindoor of May 2025.

Azerbaijan Foreign Ministry had, on May 7, 2025, condemned the Indian strikes against Pakistan-based terror targets. "We condemn military attacks against the Islamic Republic of Pakistan that killed and injured several civilians," the Azerbaijani Ministry had said.

Kashmir issue

Azerbaijan has also been vocal on the Kashmir issue at the international level, often calling for its "resolution". Mr. Bayramov in his remarks on Friday downplayed the differences between the two sides. "We have touched upon a number of issues. I believe Azerbaijan-India relations are on their way to developing to a higher level," said Mr. Bayramov.

Mr. Jaishankar's visit to Baku is the first bilateral visit by an Indian External Affairs Minister in eight years. The late External Affairs Minister Sushma Swaraj had visited Azerbaijan in April 2018 for a Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) Ministerial meeting.

Official sources here described the remarks from both sides on Friday as a sign of "diplomatic reset" as India expects to exert pressure on Turkiye and Pakistan by drawing Azerbaijan close.

Will continue to help with critical drugs for Iran: govt.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) has denied Iranian media reports claiming that India rejected Tehran's request to transport life-saving medicines. It said the two sides remain in contact on the matter as part of a humanitarian effort.

"We remain in contact with our Iranian counterparts to facilitate the transport of life-saving medicines as a humanitarian gesture," Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at a press conference

The clarification followed reports in Iranian media quoting Taher Abdolhay, managing director of Iran Air (Homa), who said on October 19 that the airline was unable to import medicines because India and Singapore had not granted flight permits for Iranian aircraft. "A proposal to transport medicines, including on passenger flights, was submitted, but permits for cargo were not granted," he added.

Ariha is receiving cultural exposure, learning Hindi: govt.

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI



The Ministry said that Ariha's mother, in picture, and father are visiting her regularly.

Ariha Shah, an Indian child in foster care in Germany, has started speaking some Hindi words, and her parents are visiting her regularly, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Friday.

"This is an issue to which we are attaching considerable importance. Our embassy in Berlin has been in regular contact with Ariha, and as part of our consular visits, they have been regularly visiting the baby," MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, in response to a query from the media.

"As I told you before, we have organised Hindi classes for her cultural immersion, along with temple visits and several other cultural exposures. She has started to speak some Hindi words. Her parents are also visiting her regularly, last on October 13. We remain committed to the welfare of the child," Mr. Jaiswal said.

During then-German Chancellor Olaf Scholz's India visit in October 2024, Ariha's case was raised at a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Mr. Scholz, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri had told presspersons then.

Mr. Misri also said that the German Chancellor assured the Prime Minister that he was "very closely following" the issue.

Born in 2021, Ariha was placed in foster care in September that year after she suffered an accidental injury, with allegations of physical abuse.

Her parents, Bhavesh and Dhara Shah, are from Mira Bhayander in Maharashtra's Thane district.

Supriya Sule alleges use of spy cams in Maharashtra polls

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI


Supriya Sule

NCP-SP leader Supriya Sule on Friday alleged the use of spy cams during voting for the Legislative Council polls for the Pune Teachers and Graduates constituencies. She said there were accusations that the ruling BJP was using pens equipped with spy cams for distributing money.

"Voters are reporting that such pens are being placed in their pockets, a video is recorded of them casting their vote for the BJP candidate, and after voting, upon showing the video, the promised money is handed over – this is the kind of activity that is underway," she posted on her social media handle X.

Calling these complaints "extremely serious and concerning," she appealed to the Election Commission and the government to take note of them. "It jeopardises the secrecy of voting and independence of voters. Practices that trample upon the fundamental principles of democracy must not be tolerated under any circumstances," she said.

She tagged the Election Commission, Maharashtra State Election Commission and the Chief Minister's Office in her post. Elections to the Legislative Council are conducted by the Chief Electoral Office of Maharashtra.

However, sources in the Maharashtra CEO said there was no formal complaint in the matter so far. "We have not received any complaints. If there are such allegations, we will ask the booth-level staff not to allow pens in the voting centre. Pens are not needed inside," the sources said.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said he was not aware of what a spy pen is. "If Supriya *tai* sends me the details, I will look into it," he said.

AI tools to be used to verify attendance in jobs scheme

The upgraded National Mobile Monitoring System used to capture attendance of workers will now have anti-tampering features, enhanced face verification to confirm on-site presence, says Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


The new features will help in identifying suspicious photographs or the repeated use of same images from worksites. ARUN KULKARNI

With an aim to plug the gaps that allegedly allowed misuse of the mobile-based application used to capture workers' attendance under the rural employment programme, Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission Gramin (VB-G RAM G), Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday announced that an upgraded version with AI-based verification and other enhanced security features that safeguard against tampering and fraudulent attendance, will be used.

Mr. Chouhan, according to a statement issued by the Press Information Bureau (PIB), said the government's priority while ensuring employment for rural workers was to "protect their wages and ensure that public funds were used transparently and for their intended purpose".

Face authentication was introduced in the National Mobile Monitoring System in March 2026 as the Ministry's response to concerns over fake attendance, under MGNREGA, that preceded the current rural programme.

However, despite the face authentication provision, in many cases "photo-to-photo capturing instead of live work images" was being done. There were also mismatches between the actual and recorded worker count. Discrepancies in the gender composition of workers were found at several worksites. Cases of the same photograph of workers appearing in multiple muster rolls, as well as mismatches between workers in morning and afternoon photographs, were also detected.

The latest version, Mr. Chouhan said, includes safeguards against cloning and tampering, along with liveness detection. "These features are designed to verify that the person appearing before the camera is a real, live worker rather than a dummy image or an old photograph. AI-based face verification has also been refined to account for differences across States and geographical regions," he said.

Apart from this, the government has also put in place a "multi-layered verification system" to ensure that payments correspond to genuine work. The system includes an AI-based photo de-duplication module that identifies suspicious or repeated photographs. The Minister explained that where such entries are detected, the wage list and Fund Transfer Order are automatically withheld until the necessary checks are completed.

Offline attendance

Mr. Chouhan also clarified that in areas where network connectivity is unavailable at a worksite, attendance can be recorded offline. An authorised exception mechanism is also available when face authentication fails for elderly workers or persons with disabilities, or when a mobile device encounters technical problems.

Scrap SIR exercise, urge scientists in letter to ECI, Centre

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

A collective of independent scientists has petitioned the Election Commission of India (ECI) and the government to scrap the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. They have demanded the immediate restoration of all eligible voters wrongly excluded.

The open letter, as of Friday, was signed by scores of researchers and academics from institutions including the Indian Institute of Science; Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi; Indian Institute of Science Education and Research, Kolkata; Institute of Mathematical Sciences, Chennai, and International Centre for Theoretical Sciences, Bengaluru. The signatories say they have endorsed the statement in their individual capacities, and that their views are personal and do not represent their institutions.

About 13 crore names have been removed from electoral rolls across the country under SIR, sparking mass protests and demands by Opposition parties and youth groups to remove the Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar. After weeks of protests, the ECI has ordered fresh verification in some States and Union Territories, including Delhi.

The scientists said that names of eligible voters, especially the poor and migrant workers, and marginalised communities, are being deleted arbitrarily, and affected citizens face cumbersome procedures. They said that there are inadequate safeguards for restoring names to the rolls and that citizens are denied a meaningful opportunity to establish their eligibility. They underlined that the SIR lacks transparency and accountability. The letter draws a parallel with the legal presumption of innocence, arguing that no genuine revision can strip citizens of their vote through such procedures.

"The right to vote is a fundamental pillar of democracy," the signatories said, adding that "democracy cannot survive when citizens are denied their voice."

Punjab CM seeks probe into electoral roll revision

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

The Punjab Assembly on Friday passed an official resolution seeking an independent probe into alleged irregularities surrounding electoral processes and the functioning of the Election Commission of India.

Taking part in the discussion on the resolution in the Assembly, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann demanded the scrapping of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, calling for an impartial investigation into the process.

He alleged the BJP was manipulating electoral rolls by adding votes in its favour and deleting those of the Opposition, and claimed that elections in Bihar, West Bengal, Haryana, and Maharashtra had been won through vote theft.

Meanwhile, noisy scenes were witnessed in the Assembly as Congress MLAs stormed the Well of the House, demanding the resignation of the Chief Minister, blaming the government for failing to tackle law and order, curb drugs, and rein in gangsterism. Congress members staged a walkout as they continued to protest.

CJP leaders appear for verification of sureties; asked to return on Nov. 3

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI


CJPs leaders after appearing before the SEM court at Mandir Marg Police Station in New Delhi on Friday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders Saurav Das, Ashutosh Ranka, and Ajinkya Shinde appeared before a Special Executive Magistrate (SEM) court at Delhi's Mandir Marg police station on Friday, two days after Mr. Das and Mr. Ranka were released from Tihar jail following seven days in judicial custody.

The appearance was in compliance with the court's earlier direction issued at the time of their release for the verification of sureties.

They have been asked to reappear on November 3. The development followed a day after Mr. Das and Mr. Ranka skipped questioning by the Delhi Police Crime Branch regarding two cases against them and requested additional time to join the investigation. The Crime Branch has yet to issue fresh notices to the two.

Speaking to the media after visiting the police station, Mr. Ranka said they were awaiting the Crime Branch's response regarding a fresh date for questioning.

The investigation relates to two cases registered on October 13 at the Connaught Place and Parliament Street police stations over allegations of trespassing into the Jantar Mantar area after it was denotified as a protest site, disobeying a government order, and obstructing police personnel on duty, among other charges.

The cases were transferred to the Crime Branch on Tuesday and further investigation is underway.

Students protest against SIR at Mumbai University, demand arrest of Gyanesh

Yohaan Varghese
MUMBAI

Students, activists and working professionals staged a protest outside Mumbai University's Kalina campus on Friday, demanding the complete withdrawal of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the arrest of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and fresh elections based on previous voter lists.

Organised by the Disha Students' Organisation and Bhagat Singh Jan Adhikar Yatra (BSJAY), the demonstration also called for the repeal of the 2023 law governing the appointment of election commissioners. Protesters alleged that the electoral roll revision exercise threatened voting rights, particularly those of marginalised communities, and accused the Election Commission of India (ECI) of acting in the BJP's interests.

Addressing the gathering, Pooja, coordinator of BSJAY, alleged that the SIR could disenfranchise Muslims, Dalits, Adivasis and working-class voters. Disha volunteer Abhinash Kumar raised concerns over alleged irregularities in the revision process, questioning changes to voter registration requirements and the functioning of the ECI-NET platform.

The demonstration also featured political rap performances, group songs and revolutionary slogans.

Congress, allies aim to create 'anarchy' through protest: BJP

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI


Sudhanshu Trivedi

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Friday accused the Congress and its allies of choosing November 1 for organising another round of protests in Delhi to foment "anarchy", drawing a parallel with the 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

At a press conference, BJP MP and spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi referred to the anti-Sikh violence in Delhi that had followed the assassination of the then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi on October 31, 1984. "They are once again going to hold a protest in Delhi on November 1. In other words, they want to remind people that, just as they pushed Delhi into chaos in 1984, they are again nurturing the thought of creating anarchy on the streets of Delhi on the same day," he claimed.

Mr. Trivedi targeted the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, describing him as a "failed product". Referring to his reported remarks in the past that his "fight" was also against the Indian state, the BJP leader accused him of undermining constitutional institutions based on false charges.

"Whether it is Europe, France, Italy, or Albania, troublemakers can be seen creating disturbances. However, nowhere do we see the Leader of the Opposition holding a sit-in outside the Prime Minister's residence or entering Akashvani building. India alone is such a case where the Congress party is going to such lengths...," he said.

Mr. Trivedi claimed that despite several attempts, the Congress could not establish Mr. Gandhi as its leader and that he had not been able to deliver the expected electoral successes. He questioned the party's internal working and alleged that it had failed to promote younger leaders and was still stuck in "dynastic politics". He pointed out that in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the Congress won only 99 seats.

Cong. holds meetings for INDIA bloc rally on Nov. 1

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal on Friday said the party held meetings to discuss mobilisation efforts for mega rally by the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) against alleged vote theft on November 1.

In a post on X, Mr. Venugopal said he, along with party leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, met party in-charge for Uttar Pradesh Rajendra Pal Gautam, State party chief Aradhana Misra, and senior leaders. He said a separate meeting was held with party incharge for Haryana Sanjay Dutt, and State party chief Rao Narender Singh.

Mr. Venugopal said the rally at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan will be the culmination of a 'Delhi Chalo' march and at least 10 lakh citizens are expected to attend it. He alleged that the initiatives were against "criminal vote *chori* orchestrated by Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar & Co. at the behest of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah". "The rally will send a strong message that we are united in protecting our democracy," he said.

Delhi HC rejects Neha Bora's plea against notice to sign peace bond

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Friday rejected a plea by All India Students' Association (AISA) president Neha Bora challenging a police notice asking her to execute a peace bond before a Special Executive Magistrate (SEM).

"I am rejecting the writ petition at this juncture," said Justice Subramonium Prasad, while pronouncing the judgment.

The judge, however, said that he has passed certain directions to the SEM on providing all material to the student leader in the proceedings.

"There are sufficient safeguards given, directions given to the Magistrate to take care. All the material has to be furnished to her," Justice Prasad said.

The court also said that before passing any order, the SEM would consider the issue of whether the bond has to be produced at the very first instance or during the course of the enquiry.

The national president of AISA had challenged a police notice directing her to furnish a bond for maintaining peace before the SEM.

₹10,000 bond

The police notice, issued on October 17 under Section 126 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), asked Ms. Bora to appear before the SEM on October 19 and show cause as to why she should not execute a personal bond of ₹10,000 with one surety "for keeping peace for a period of enquiry".

SC backs voters' right to prosecute candidates

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has held in a judgment that ordinary private citizens can file criminal complaints against candidates for giving false information or concealing information while filing their nomination papers for an election.

The judgment by a Bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu said the law does not insist that only public servants or competent authorities were eligible to lodge complaints against electoral candidates.

The court's judgment empowers the vigilant citizen-voter with the *locus standi* to directly act against dishonesty in electoral politics, and ensure transparency in polls right from the stage of filing nominations.

Personal affidavits

Candidates have to file personal affidavits along with their nominations. Senior advocate Sanjay Nuli, who appeared in the case, pointed out that these affidavits were part of legislative efforts to maintain the purity of elections and a healthy democracy.

Citizens can file criminal complaints against candidates for false information in nominations, it says

Voters must be educated and well-informed about the contesting candidates, including the latter's assets, educational qualifications and criminal antecedents. Concealing personal information or filing false details to hoodwink the voters is a non-cognisable and bailable offence under Section 125-A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951. The Section provides that a guilty party would be liable to face imprisonment for six months, fine or both.

Justice Datta interpreted that the rigour of Section 195 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), that only a complaint lodged by a public servant must be taken cognisance of by a court of law, did not affect Section 125-A of the 1951 Act.

"If indeed it were the intention of the legislature that cognisance of any offence relating to the furnishing of false information by a candidate in an affidavit with intent of being elected in an election could only be taken if the complainant were a public servant, the same could have been provided by an amendment of Section 195 CrPC," the court noted.

Interpretation

"No court would be barred from taking cognisance of an alleged offence under Section 125-A, even on the complaint lodged by a private person. This interpretation is fortified by the absence of any provision in any enactment stipulating that a complaint in relation to an offence under Section 125-A can only be lodged by a public servant," Justice Datta, who authored the judgment, held.

INBRIEF



Saudi security crisis prolongs IndiGo flight suspension

IndiGo has extended the suspension of its flights to and from Saudi Arabia amid escalating security concerns in the region, said the Indian Embassy in Riyadh on Friday. "IndiGo flights to and from Riyadh will remain cancelled until 31 October 2026 (inclusive), while flights to and from Jeddah, Dammam and Madinah will remain cancelled until 27 October 2026 (inclusive)," the mission said. The latest extension of flight cancellations follows a series of Houthi attacks in Saudi Arabia on Wednesday, including a strike on King Fahd International Airport in Dammam that killed an Indian national, and a separate attack on Saudi Aramco's Shaybah oilfield. PTI

India confirms safety of 14 nationals after yacht attack

India on Friday said that its 14 nationals onboard a yacht involved in an incident off the coast of Yemen are safe and it would continue to work to ensure their well-being. Arab media on Thursday quoted spokesperson of the Houthi militia Yahya Saree as claiming that Saudi Arabian forces targeted the Indian yacht near Yuqar Island near the Yemeni coast in the Red Sea."Reports suggest that all 14 Indian nationals are safe and located around Hodeidah in Yemen," the Indian mission in Yemen posted on social media on Friday. The incident comes amid an escalation of hostilities between Houthis and Saudi Arabia, with both sides targeting each other's facilities. PTI

Odisha, A.P. brace for storm as low pressure intensifies

Bay system is likely to cross the southern Odisha-northern Andhra Pradesh coast by October 28, says IMD; Odisha govt. cancels leaves of all officials, keeps disaster response forces on standby

The Hindu Bureau
BHUBANESWAR

The weather system over the Bay of Bengal is likely to intensify into a cyclone and cross the southern Odisha-northern Andhra Pradesh coast by October 28.

A low-pressure area formed over the east-central and adjoining southeast Bay of Bengal at 5.30 a.m. on Friday is expected to become a depression on Saturday, a deep depression on Sunday and a cyclonic storm by Monday morning, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said. It may then move towards the north Andhra Pradesh and south Odisha coast.

"Under the impact of the low-pressure system, several Odisha districts are likely to witness heavy to very heavy rainfall from October 26. On October 27, a red alert for heavy rain has been issued for Puri, Ganjam, and Gajapati districts," said Suresh Pujari, Odisha's Revenue and Disaster Management Minister, after a high-level meeting. Subsequently, a majority of Odisha districts would experience cyclonic weather on October 27, he said, adding that the IMD was yet to forecast the exact area of the landfall of the predicted cyclone.



Under the impact of the weather system, several districts along the coast are likely to witness heavy rainfall. K.R. DEEPAK

"We have been informed through different weather models that the cyclone may enter the landmass between Odisha's Gopalpur and Andhra Pradesh's Kakinada and move as a depression towards Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh through interior Odisha districts," the Minister said. Mr. Pujari said that depending on the intensity of the weather system, people will be evacuated, and their lives and property safeguarded. "Government employees have been asked to return to their offices. Leaves of officials have been cancelled," he said. Fishermen have been advised to return to the coast. All disaster response forces, including the National Disaster Response Force and Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force, are on standby.

Meanwhile, K. Naga Ratna, Head of the Amaravati Meteorological Centre, Andhra Pradesh, said, "It would be at least a severe cyclonic storm." Some models indicate a very severe cyclonic storm, with wind reaching a speed of up to 145 kmph, she added, and a storm surge of 1 to 2 metres is expected. The IMD's sea warning for October 27 is higher, at 120 to 165 kmph, gusting to 185 kmph, off the north A.P. coast.

The landfall point remains uncertain. "The system could cross anywhere between West Godavari and Srikakulam districts, with some models pointing to Visakhapatnam and others to Kakinada and Konaseema," she said.

The IMD has issued a red warning for extremely heavy rain at isolated places in Visakhapatnam and Anakapalli districts on October 27.

On October 28, red warnings cover Alluri Sitharama Raju, Anakapalli, Kakinada, East Godavari, Konaseema and West Godavari, while Visakhapatnam is under an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rain.

(With inputs from Visakhapatnam)

Ladakh talks fail to resume amid rift over govt. proposal

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Original agenda adopted by civil society groups now stands hijacked, a new forum alleged

The proposed talks between the Union Home Ministry and representatives from Ladakh failed to take place on Thursday amid growing differences among civil society groups over the Centre's draft proposal for the Union Territory.

Leh's civil society groups, particularly the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), had termed the 32-page draft, which proposes a new governance structure for Ladakh, "a departure from the earlier promises".

A sub-committee of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), mandated to talk with Ladakh representatives, was scheduled to meet on Thursday in New Delhi to further discuss the 32-page draft shared with the LAB and KDA on October 15 in Leh. However, the talks did not take place.

The Civil Society Forum of Ladakh (CSFL), a Leh-based civil society group, is projecting itself as a new stakeholder in the issue. "This forum observes with deep concern that the original agenda adopted by LAB for constitutional safeguards for land, jobs, culture and environment stands hijacked. The dialogue is now dominated by one individual (climate activist) Sonam Wangchuk and KDA, compromising the genuine interests of districts and the Buddhist community," said the members of CSFL in a joint statement.

The group comprises BJP leader and ex-Member of Parliament Thupstan Chhewang, ex-chief executive councillor of the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council-Leh (LAHDC-Leh) Rigzen Spalbar; ex-legislator Tsering Samphel, representatives of Thiksey and Thuksey Rinpoche, and also members of the Ladakh Buddhist Association (LBA).

"The LAB and KDA no longer represent inclusive voice of all districts," the forum said, while appealing to the Centre to hold panchayat elections and "enhance powers of hill councils till Union Territory-level constitutional settlement is reached".

RSS affiliate opposes Starlink's India entry

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Swadeshi Jagaran Manch (SJM) has urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to deny operating permissions for SpaceX's satellite internet service, Starlink, in India. SJM is an affiliate of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and the recommendation follows a protest march led by SJM members.

"It's unfortunate that instead of responding to clarifications sought from his company, on national security grounds, Shri Elon Musk has chosen to make allegations on Indian businesses and the government indirectly," Ashwani Mahajan, SJM's national co-convener said. The government is yet to approve requests from three companies for spectrum allotment.

Driving licence rule amendments seek to raise bar for learner's test

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The Union government has proposed changes to driving licence rules that could make the learner's test more rigorous while moving several services online and making some of them free.

The draft amendments to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, propose raising the pass mark for the preliminary learner's test from 60% to 75%. Applicants will get 15 days, instead of seven, to complete the learner's licence process, and will have to take a safe-driving tutorial of at least 30 minutes.

Applicants will have to submit separate proof of address, age and identity. The list of acceptable documents will include Aadhaar, voter ID, passport, e-ration card and certain government-issued identity documents. Electricity and household gas bills issued within the past three months can also be used as address proof. Foreign applicants should show that they are legally present in India.



The draft amendments propose raising the pass mark for the preliminary learner's test from 60% to 75%. FILE PHOTO

A new Form 2A is proposed to bring together applications for licence renewal, duplicate licences, changes to names or addresses, updates to personal details and the addition of vehicle categories. The draft also proposes no fee for changing a licence holder's name, address or other recorded details.

Medical disclosure

As per the draft amendments, applicants will have to provide more medical information, including whether they have epilepsy or other seizure disorders, hearing impairment, night blindness, medication allergies or surgical implants. People who report epilepsy or a seizure disorder, along with a seizure in the previous three years, or who are on anti-epileptic medication at present, will not be eligible for a driving licence.

The rules say that details about medicine allergies, implants and certain other medical information will be used only if the person is hospitalised after a road accident.

The draft also proposes collecting information such as blood group and emergency contact details in licence applications.

The draft was put up on the government website earlier this week. The Centre has invited feedback from public and other stakeholders within 30 days, after which it will be taken up for consideration.

UN Security Council faces a 'legitimacy deficit', says India

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

India has highlighted the United Nations Security Council's struggles to deliver peace in some of the "gravest" global conflicts, emphasising that authority derived from victory in the Second World War cannot compensate for a "deficit in legitimacy" of an unrepresentative UNSC today.

India's Permanent Representative to the UN, Ambassador Harish Parvathaneni, while addressing the 'Question of Equitable representation on and increase in the membership of Security Council' in the UN General Assembly, said on Thursday that an organisation that cannot renew its principal organ will find it ever harder to command authority in a world that has moved far beyond 1945.

"History can be a guide for what not to do. It cannot determine today's choices," he said. He added that the credibility of the UN is "called into question" as conflicts multiply and the council struggles to respond.



Harish Parvathaneni

India also called out the deliberate suppression of sacrifices made by nations in the world wars while an organisation "crafted of the victors, for the victors and by the victors" did not include concerns of the victims.

India, which is vying for a non-permanent UNSC seat for the 2028-29 term, said that the Asia-Pacific Group accounting for more than 60% of the world's population has no choice but to be limited in its representation. "Nowhere else would the injustice of this gross under-representation have continued for so long," he said.

'Central imbalance'

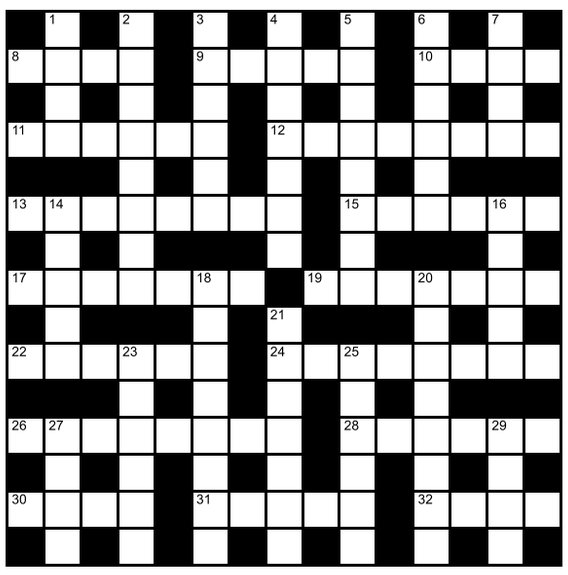
The 15-nation council has five permanent veto-wielding members – China, France, Russia, the UK and the U.S. while 10 members are elected to sit at the horseshoe high-table for two-year terms. India has been calling for an expansion in both the permanent and non-permanent categories of UNSC membership, as Parvathaneni emphasised that a reform that expands only the non-permanent category leaves the central imbalance untouched and further entrenches the status quo.

TH CROSSWORD + 14931

(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8 Juliet is in front of sick girl tumbling after Jack (4)
9 Kind of taste satsuma might possess (5)
10 Before 9, United Nations gets operating system (4)
11 Cheese maker's tenner returned (6)
12 Exaggerated usage, perhaps, about slaughter (8)
13 Where one may find figure eights left by sportspersons... (3,5)
15 Distress call from vessel after vessel (3,3)
17 Frank, a singer playing sitar around North America (7)
19 In absence of a coach, diced and covered with gin cocktail to make pasta-like dumplings (7)
22 Name child under guardian after editor (6)
24 Wrongly indicate a series of elements (8)
26 Disfigured Thane cop's memorial (8)
28 John and Theodore plundered (6)
30 Put it in big enchilada initially and sink teeth in (4)
31 With love, new elm may produce citrus fruit (5)
32 Give out loan instalment before time (4)

Down

1 Pest is in custody of policeman (4)
2 Horrible rain near plot results in flatworms (8)
3 Boy leaves dustbin for Hoffman (6)
4 Oddly move Amos, after dropping Mike, and go away (7)
5 Tailless feline goes around mineral spring resort for period from birth till death (8)
6 Hide behind Russian, Mr Bond (6)
7 Advertisement may be seen on board behind him (4)
14 Spoiled rice before commencement of dinner and sobbed (5)
16 Pest from Andhra Pradesh covered (5)
18 Shattered emerald strewn around front of pine tree (3,5)
20 Means from criminal with pieces of paper currency (8)
21 Amish is cooking Japanese delicacy (7)
23 Animal having crushed ego in climax (6)
25 Story book is a gift (6)
27 Lake in Madikeri estate (4)
29 Ruler's firearm is damaged after throwing far away (4)

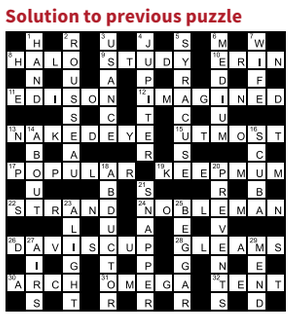
SUDOKU

5			6	7	1	2		
			8				1	7
			2					6
	6				4	3		
		5				1		
		2	5				8	
1					6			
7	9				8			
		4	7	5	3			1

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

No.SS7040 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

1	2	6	5	9	3	8	4	7
7	4	8	6	1	2	3	9	5
3	5	9	4	8	7	6	2	1
4	1	5	8	7	9	2	3	6
6	9	7	3	2	5	4	1	8
8	3	2	1	6	4	7	5	9
5	6	4	7	3	1	9	8	2
9	7	1	2	4	8	5	6	3
2	8	3	9	5	6	1	7	4

FAITH

Always serving the Lord

Garuda is always with Lord Narayana. In Brindavana, wherever Krishna went, Garuda flew above Him, sheltering Him from the sun. In his Stotra ratna, Alavandar enumerates the ways in which Garuda serves the Lord, said Thenthirupperai Aravindalochanan in a discourse. Alavandar points out that Garuda is the Lord's servant, His friend, His vehicle, His seat, His flag, His canopy, and His fan. Alavandar further says that Garuda is the embodiment of the Vedas. In all Vishnu temples, we find a shrine for Garuda, where Garuda faces the Lord.

During the war against Ravana, Indrajit used the naga pasa to bind Rama and Lakshmana. But when Garuda appeared, the snakes, which as arrows had bound Rama and Lakshmana, fled, thus releasing the two princes. Garuda then touched them, and the brothers' wounds healed, and they became stronger than before. Garuda then lifted them and embraced them. Rama said that meeting Garuda gave Him the feeling that He was meeting His father Dasaratha.

Tirumala, where Lord Srinivasa resides, is also called Garudadri. When Bhu Devi requested Varaha to remain on the earth, the latter asked Garuda to bring seven hills that He had in Sri Vaikunta. Because Garuda brought the seven hills from Sri Vaikunta, the hills came to be called Garudadri. Although we now have the practice of referring to just one of the seven hills as Garudadri, all of them have the name Garudadri. The Garuda sevai festival of Kanchipuram Varadaraja Perumal temple is famous, although all temples have the processional deity carried on Garuda vahana during the main temple festival.

Falling short

Marco Rubio's second visit to India this year yielded little in terms of results

The United States Secretary of State's three-day visit to India, his second in five months, came at a significant time in U.S. politics. Marco Rubio's Mumbai trip this week was just ahead of the U.S. midterm elections, which would mark the midpoint of President Donald Trump's second term in office – a point at which the incumbent normally begins to focus on legacy, and possible contenders for the next Presidential election (Mr. Rubio is expected to be one), and start to look for possible partners and friendships around the world. In addition, his visit also raised hopes in New Delhi of a reset in bilateral ties, battered by two years of uncertainty over the Trump administration's actions. This would include positive moves towards concluding the Bilateral Trade Agreement, reassuring India about U.S. sanctions on the import of Russian oil, preparations for upcoming Trump meets with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the Manila (ASEAN) and Miami (G-20) summits, discussing plans for the Quad Summit (on the sidelines of the ASEAN summit) that India has been trying to host, and setting a date for Mr. Trump's India visit. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar's invitation also offered Mr. Rubio an opportunity to meet their UAE counterpart, Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan, to discuss the Gulf situation and to restore energy security and connectivity. And finally, Mr. Rubio's visit to the Jamnagar Reliance refinery, led to speculation of some major deals on energy, possibly offering more discounts as he pitched for India to buy more American and U.S.-licensed Venezuelan oil.

Given all the high expectations, the visit was bound to come up short. The optics of his visit to Mumbai and Jamnagar, but not New Delhi, which was announced by the U.S. Ambassador to India, gave the Opposition fodder to question the real purpose of the visit. Despite Mr. Rubio's two visits to India and more than six by Mr. Jaishankar to the U.S. since Mr. Trump took office, relations remain on edge, with issues on trade, tariffs, H-1B restrictions and anti-immigrant measures unaddressed. Also, the U.S.'s narrative on Operation Sindoor (2025), growing ties with Pakistan, and the Trump administration's rhetoric on India's economy, diaspora and Russian oil trade have added to India's unhappiness. The two sides did not announce any agreements and Mr. Jaishankar and Mr. Rubio did not hold a joint press address. However, as they did at the U.S. Independence Day's 250th anniversary celebrations in Delhi in May, they attended the "Freedom 250" event in Mumbai. Mr. Rubio acknowledged that while no two countries would agree on all issues, he said the U.S.-India alignment on core issues of national interest was "extraordinary". From this point on, Mr. Rubio must walk that talk, with a view to ensuring that India-U.S. ties are able to move on from the difficulties of the last few years.

In the crossfire

India must adopt a pro-active position in the Saudi-Houthi conflict

The killing of an Indian national in a Houthi attack on Saudi Arabia's Dammam airport is a grim reminder of the dangers the kingdom's Indian community faces as the conflict between Riyadh and Yemen's Shia militants escalates. Since the fighting between Saudi Arabia and the Houthis resumed in July, at least two Indians have been killed and 14 others wounded. On Thursday, the Houthis claimed that a yacht with 14 Indians was targeted by Saudi forces near Yemen's Zuqar island in the Red Sea and that rescue operations were under way. As the Houthis, who control parts of Northern Yemen and its entire Red Sea coast, step up attacks on Saudi infrastructure, including oil facilities and airports, Indians, who are the kingdom's largest expat community, risk getting caught in the crossfire. With flights disrupted, thousands of Indian pilgrims are stranded. India has condemned Houthi attacks, saying that it "stands in solidarity" with Saudi Arabia. With no end in sight to the fighting and a high possibility of Israel and the U.S. resuming their Iran strikes, further violence and instability in West Asia could make India's choices increasingly difficult.

The Saudi-Houthi conflict dates back to the Houthi takeover of Sana'a, Yemen's capital, in 2014. A year later, Saudi Arabia began bombing Yemen to drive the Houthis out. But years of Saudi bombing of one of the poorest Arab countries have proved counterproductive; the Houthis consolidated support among the tribes of northern Yemen and built a powerful territorial army and naval force. The Saudi-Houthi ceasefire of 2022 collapsed in July 2026 after Saudi Arabia recklessly bombed Sana'a airport, to prevent an Iranian plane with a Houthi delegation from landing. The Houthis subsequently began attacking Saudi Arabia's critical infrastructure, and launched a ground offensive against the Saudi-backed forces in Yemen. The Houthi attacks pose the biggest security challenge to Mohammed bin Salman, Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince and the main architect of the war on Yemen, in decades. Massive Saudi air strikes have neither defeated the Houthis nor restored the kingdom's deterrence. With its wealth, natural resources, infrastructure and tenuous palace politics, the kingdom remains exposed to Houthi missile and drone attacks, with few good options for a way out. India must prepare a contingency plan for worst-case scenarios. Its immediate priority should be to evacuate stranded Indian pilgrims. It should also articulate a stronger position for stability and work with Arab countries and Tehran to push for a diplomatic settlement to the Iran crisis. For peace to prevail in the Persian Gulf, the guns directed at Iran must first fall silent.

BJP has no bad option, Congress has no good option



Varghese K. George

On October 16, 2026, Congress president and Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, Mallikarjun Kharge, wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, seeking an all-party meeting to discuss the government's delimitation proposals before they were finalised and introduced in Parliament. It was Mr. Kharge's fourth letter since April seeking such a meeting. On October 19, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju replied, saying that the government had repeatedly sought the Congress's cooperation, including through letters to Mr. Kharge in March and April and discussions with him and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi.

Mr. Rijiju also said that the government had held consultations with several other Opposition parties. Yet, his reply showed once again that the Centre had no intention of disclosing its precise proposals on delimitation. Without explicitly saying so, Mr. Rijiju's letter suggested that the government planned to bring in legislation on delimitation while withholding the details, thereby preventing a possible public debate on the issue.

What the real debate is

Given the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s plans to move the legislation by stealth, one has to go by what is publicly available to examine the options before the BJP and the Opposition, particularly the Congress, on delimitation. Women's reservation is an unnecessary distraction and fog in this debate. The issue is settled: one-third of the seats in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies will be reserved for women when the next delimitation takes place, regardless of the total number of seats. The real debate concerns the increase in the size of the Lok Sabha and how it is distributed among the States.

In April 2026, the government said that it would retain the current proportion of States in an enlarged Lok Sabha of up to 850 seats. The proposal would increase the cap on the number of Lok Sabha seats by more than 50%, translating into a corresponding increase in the number of seats in each State while maintaining their existing proportions.

However, the government subsequently introduced Bills that required the distribution of Lok Sabha seats on the basis of the 2011 Census. It was a curious case of the government promising something and then pushing legislation that would render the implementation of that very promise unconstitutional, no less. Whether this was incompetence or duplicity, neither possibility was reassuring. The contradiction unravelled, and the Bills failed. One must now go by the BJP's publicly stated position: which is to maintain the current proportion of individual States in an enlarged Lok Sabha of up to 850 seats. Implementing this position would require a constitutional amendment. This analysis assumes that what the BJP says and what it writes in the draft Bills will be the same, unlike the last time around.

Delimitation leaves the Bharatiya Janata Party with political opportunities and the Congress party with limited options

The Congress is opposed to this position and has a counter-proposal. The Congress wants the current strength of 543 seats in the Lok Sabha, and their distribution among the States, to continue. This too requires a constitutional amendment, and hence, is dead on arrival. As it stands today, the Constitution requires Lok Sabha seats to be reallocated among States on the basis of the 2027 Census. The Congress currently considers the defeat of any BJP amendment as a success, regardless of the assured failure of its own proposal. But it needs to analyse more carefully what that would entail.

The BJP's expansion strategy

What could the BJP's political calculation be? In the absence of a constitutional amendment, the 550 seats possible under the present provisions of the Constitution can be reallocated, to the huge advantage of the heartland States, and potentially, the BJP. That being the reality, why does the BJP strongly push for a larger Lok Sabha? The party wants to increase the number of seats and is even willing to continue with the relative disadvantage of the heartland States unaddressed. That needs an explanation.

The Congress and adjacent entities are opposed to an increase in the strength of the Lok Sabha. The argument is that even if the proportionate strength of each State is maintained, a larger Lok Sabha would widen the disparity in absolute numbers between them. Lok Sabha majorities are determined by absolute numbers and not proportions, it has been argued. For a majority in the Lok Sabha, you need 50% plus one vote for usual majorities; for special majorities, two-thirds is needed. If current proportions are maintained, every State will retain its current relative strength in determining a Lok Sabha majority, and its influence in national politics.

The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam is willing to support delimitation that maintains the current proportion, regardless of the total numbers. But the party wants clarity on how that will be legislated. The Centre is tightlipped and Mr. Rijiju's latest letter avoids any mention of this. The increase in absolute numbers while maintaining the proportion does not bring evident advantages for the BJP.

So, what might the BJP be calculating? A possibility is that the BJP is wise enough to decipher that pushing peninsular India into further marginalisation is not helpful for national integration or for its own ambition to be a truly national party that has legitimacy in all parts of the country. Therefore, it is willing to keep the proportion intact in exchange for a significant spike in absolute numbers for more populated States.

A second reason is a publicly stated one: the implementation of the women's quota can be done without impacting the existing male members, by adding 50% more seats. Some see a conspiracy to gerrymander constituency borders before the next general election. Another reason is that as demands for caste-based representation grow, expanding the Lok Sabha would create more room to accommodate competing claims. This is particularly relevant considering the BJP's focus on social engineering. The bigger the numbers, the easier it will be for the BJP in its social engineering.

The BJP is in a win-win situation as far as delimitation is concerned. If it manages to pass the amendment, it will have additional seats to play around with in its social engineering. If it cannot pass an amendment, a larger proportion of the existing seats will shift to its strongholds, while keeping its alleged gerrymandering plans equally viable. Any increase, if at all, in the probability of a national BJP majority through delimitation is linked to the reallocation of the seats, and not to an increase in the total number of seats while retaining the current proportion.

The Congress's difficult choices

Where does that leave the Congress? The Congress assumes success in preventing a BJP amendment. It must know that it has no viable path to keeping both the current strength and the shares of individual States intact. The only two options are: first, the number of Lok Sabha seats increases, but the individual share of States remains unchanged through a constitutional amendment, as the BJP says but has not written in a draft legislation. Second, the number of seats does not increase, but the existing seats get reallocated on the basis of the latest Census, leading to a massive slash in the representation of Keralam, Tamil Nadu and other States in similar positions both as absolute numbers and proportion. The BJP will blame the Congress and the Left, if the second option plays out, while reaping the advantage of the additional share in the heartland. The BJP has two good options from its vantage point; the Congress has two bad options to choose from, from its vantage point.

varghese.g@thehindu.co.in

U.S. midterms — Republicans face growing Blue wave



Anil Raman

A retired Brigadier and a research fellow in the Geopolitics Program of Takshashila Institution

With about 10 days left for the U.S. midterm elections on November 3, talk of a Democratic wave has shifted from opinion polls to voting reality. Every major forecast now predicts the Democrats will win the House of Representatives. Statistician Nate Silver gives them a 75% chance of winning the Senate, which Republicans held strongly just a month ago. The Grand Old Party faces five main problems: a President who is a liability, weak candidates, money not swaying voters, fissures in their heartland, and a party base turning against its own.

A President on the defensive

Let us begin with the President. Midterms are often a verdict on the White House. Donald Trump has made this election about himself, telling crowds to "pretend I'm on the ballot". His approval rating is below 40%. In September, he told Republicans in tight races that he would visit "every one of those 35 places". But he has campaigned in fewer than a third. Most stops have been in States he won easily, such as Oklahoma, Alabama, Tennessee, and Montana, which he said was his way "to thank them". When a President rallies supporters in States that he won by huge margins two years earlier instead of margin seats, it conveys a hint of desperation.

The next issue is candidate quality. Texas has not elected a Democrat to the Senate since 1988. This year, the Republican nominee is Ken Paxton, who was impeached by the Texas House in 2023 and later acquitted by the State Senate. He was also observed partying in 2025 in Dubai with two Pakistani-American federal fugitives who were also his donors. His Democratic opponent, James Talarico, a former teacher and State legislator, was leading by two points in a Fox News poll (but the latest Fox News poll listed for October 15-19 showed a 49%-49% tie); and by three points in a University of Texas poll (September 25-October 5).

The third problem is in the heartland. Kansas has sent only Republicans to this Senate seat since 1919, the longest streak for any party in U.S. history. Republican incumbent Roger Marshall is tied in the polls with Adam Hamilton, a Methodist pastor who started one of the country's largest churches. In Nebraska – a State Mr. Trump won by over 20 points – Democrats have stepped aside for Dan Osborn, a former union leader running as an independent. He is about three points behind Senator Pete Ricketts. When a party spends the last two weeks defending strongholds of Kansas and Nebraska, it is on the back foot.

Multiple Republican vulnerabilities are strengthening Democratic hopes

The fourth issue is money. Elon Musk, who split from Mr. Trump last year, is now the biggest known donor in this election, having given over $276 million to Republican groups since July. Recent filings show that Mr. Musk gave $158 million to the Senate Leadership Fund and a separate $10 million to Lone Star Liberty PAC, which supports Mr. Paxton's Senate campaign. Even so, Mr. Talarico, the Democratic candidate, is still ahead. Money can buy TV advertisements, but it cannot easily overcome a national mood shaped by high prices, an unpopular war with Iran, and immigration raids.

The lesson from Ohio

Ohio combines these issues, making it the most revealing race. Vivek Ramaswamy, a former presidential candidate backed by Mr. Trump, seemed confirmed for Governor in a State that the President has won three times. His opponent, Amy Acton, looked like an easy target. As Ohio's highly unpopular health director during the COVID-19 pandemic, she ordered lockdowns, faced armed protesters at her home, and had Republicans try to strip her powers before she resigned in 2020. Mr. Ramaswamy and his supporters have spent about $101 million on advertisements, including $36 million of his own money, about three times what Ms. Acton has spent. Still, he was trailing her recently by about three points on average. Among independent voters, his net rating is minus 25, the lowest for a Republican candidate for Governor in Ohio this century.

This week, his campaign announced plans to spend $4 million promoting an advertisement featuring Ms. Acton's estranged mother calling her a liar, drawing criticism from Republicans, including Governor Mike DeWine and Senator Jon Husted.

Much of this can be explained by the national mood, since the party's Senate candidate in Ohio is also behind by a similar amount. But some of Mr. Ramaswamy's problems come from within his own party. His rival in the Republican primary, Casey Putsch, posted a video of himself with a rifle inviting him to play "cowboys versus Indians". He called Mr. Ramaswamy an "anchor baby" and said that there was "nothing remotely American" about him. Still, nearly one in five Republican primary voters picked Mr. Putsch. Far-right commentator Nick Fuentes told his followers to oppose Mr. Ramaswamy, while students at a conservative youth event questioned whether a Hindu could represent a Christian State. The anger goes back to the H-1B controversy in December 2024, when Mr. Ramaswamy said American culture undervalued excellence, which angered 'Make America Great Again' (MAGA) voters. Now, the same party that once questioned who belongs in America is asking the same question about its own candidate.

Self-inflicted wounds

Ohio is an apt lesson for the Republicans. A party can get through having an unpopular President, a weak candidate, or a tough electoral map in any given year. But it is much harder when all these problems happen at once and the party's base starts judging its own candidates by their race, background and religion. If Democrats win Texas, Kansas, Nebraska, or Ohio on November 3, it will be a wave, and the Republicans will have helped make it. Perhaps they deserve that loss.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Persistent confrontation

It is a matter of serious concern that confrontations with Chinese troops continue to occur along the border, despite several rounds of consultations (Front page, "ITBP D-G says face-off with China continues in Arunachal Pradesh", October 23). While continuing talks with China to resolve border issues is important, Beijing's duplicitous approach should be brought to the attention of Chinese interlocutors. Further, it is unfortunate that India's imports from China have been growing rapidly and the trade deficit with its neighbour has widened in recent years. Unrestrained imports from a neighbour that continues to be confrontational along the border could embolden it to pursue even more aggressive border activities inimical to India's interests.

Kosaraju Chandramouli,
Hyderabad

Coffee first, tourism second

The feature, "Karnataka's coffee country: Inside its most immersive plantation stays" (October 23), shows coffee country discovering that the view can pay better than the crop. That trade-off needs watching. A plantation stay succeeds because the plantation itself works — the pruning, the pickers and the processing. Estates that convert too much land into accommodation risk discovering that the real attraction was the agriculture. Used well, tourism is a hedge against coffee price fluctuations, not a replacement for coffee cultivation. The estates most likely to endure are those where guests buy the beans as well as the bed, and where the ledger still puts coffee first. Income from stays that is reinvested in shade trees and soil health strengthens the attraction; income that merely adds more rooms dilutes it.

Jackie Omotalade,
Pittsburgh, U.S.

Postal services

Though communication has shifted to digital platforms, we must remember generations who depended on letters to connect with loved ones. The red letterbox symbolised bonds that united people across distances. The dedication of postal staff deserves appreciation throughout the year, not merely on October 10.

A.P. Thiruvadi,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.



Police personnel deployed at the Chorbagan Sorbojanin Durga Puja pandal following a stampede, in Kolkata. PTI

Death in the time of Durga Puja

On October 17, a stampede broke out at a Durga Puja pandal in north Kolkata, claiming 19 lives. The pandal, erected in a narrow space with dim lighting, was filled with people soon after it started raining. **Shrabana Chatterjee** and **Shiv Sahay Singh** report on the lapses that led to the tragedy and the questions it has raised about accountability in West Bengal, where the new government's first Durga Puja celebrations have been marred by controversy

On the evening of October 17, Subham Sonkar, 32, was out pandal-hopping with a cousin, both of them dressed in festive finery. It was Saptami, the day of elaborate ritual worship of goddess Durga, when crowds throng the pandals. As a sudden, sharp spell of rain sent people rushing into the Chorbagan Sorbojanin Durga Puja pandal in north Kolkata, pandemonium broke out and the two cousins got separated. While Sonkar died in the crush, the cousin she was with survived.

Vishal Bhel, another cousin, was not at the pandal at the time. He received a call from an unknown number asking him to reach Medical College Kolkata, about one-and-a-half kilometres away from the pandal. Bhel stood shell-shocked outside the emergency building around midnight, having just seen Sonkar's body. "People had walked all over her after she had fallen down," he said. "Her whole body was bruised and her face looked like she had been in a lot of pain. I can't believe how a happy Durga Puja moment turned into her last moment on earth in just a second."



Scores of family members of the injured and deceased waited in nervous anticipation and grief as the rest of the city continued to celebrate. A woman sitting at the gate of the emergency building was inconsolable. "Call me Ma one last time," she cried. "I have nothing left to live for. Please call me Ma one last time, I beg you."

A few hours earlier, her daughter, Piyali Pramanik, 25, had made a video call to her mother when she was on her way to pandal-hop. Three members of the family died in the tragedy: Pramanik; her sister-in-law, 37-year-old Tager Bhej, and Bhej's child, 14-year-old Sandip. Both Pramanik and Bhej were from Purba Bardhaman district and had travelled 100 km to participate in the festivities in West Bengal's capital, where every year, temporary structures are turned into elaborate works of art, streets glow with lights, the sound of drums fills the air, and food stalls sell delicious Bengali *bhog* (food offering).

The stampede also claimed the lives of both parents of 25-year-old Pritish Ghosh, a resident of Kolkata's Baranagar area. Dilip Ghosh (59) and Dipali Ghosh (45) had gone to the puja pandal; neither survived. Moved by the plight of the young man, West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari offered to become his guardian.

Among the 19 people who lost their lives in the stampede that occurred at 7:40 p.m., according to the police, 13 were female and six were male. Four were minors. Twenty-five others were injured. Preliminary post-mortem reports at the Kolkata Police morgue attributed most of the deaths to traumatic asphyxia caused by chest compression.

Mismanagement at the pandal

The Chorbagan Sorbojanin Durga Puja pandal was inaugurated by Chief Minister Adhikari on October 12 and generated a lot of attention on social media as a must-visit spot for puja revellers.

> There were no policemen and there was no security. The organisers made wrong announcements and spread panic, which led to the stampede.
> **RUNU DAS**
> Resident, Chorbagan area

The theme of the pandal was 'Aarav-Beyond Sound'. In the narrow by-lanes of north Kolkata, the artist of the pandal had created an even narrower, darker space, inviting revellers to experience silence in the presence of the goddess. Inside the pandal, the grey idol of goddess Durga rose nearly 10 metres above the ground. With 10 hands, two of them holding lotus flowers, she sat silently in *padmasana* or the lotus pose.

The pandal was in its 91st year. Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders had taken over the organising committee only three months ago, following the party's victory in West Bengal. The pandal's publicity material, widely circulated in the public domain, identifies BJP Jorasanko MLA Vijay Ojha as the puja committee chairman; BJP north Kolkata district president Tamaghna Ghosh as its chief adviser; and Debdeep Adhikari, nephew of Chief Minister Adhikari, as its chief patron.

Several eyewitnesses and Adhikari claimed that a misleading announcement by the pandal organisers, accompanied by whistle-blowing, had triggered panic. "You all should leave at once; the pandal can collapse any moment," said the announcer, according to videos making the rounds on social media. In another set of videos, people can be seen holding umbrellas and entering the pandal minutes before the crowd crush.

The road leading to the pandal was not more than 16 feet wide and a part of it had been bifurcated for the movement of VIPs. "They only allowed VIPs to walk through, so where was the average person supposed to go?" an angry resident, who had helped in rescue and relief efforts, said to the media.

Rajesh Srivastava, a resident of Agarpara in Kolkata, who survived the stampede, said people had been packed inside the pandal for almost 30 minutes. "There was major mismanagement by the organisers. When it started to rain, more people rushed into the pandal. They were pushing in from one side, while bodies lay on the other," said Srivastava, who was discharged from a private hospital on October 19. "There were no policemen at the site for at least 45 minutes."



An ambulance carrying Durga Puja pandal stampede victims stops in front of the emergency building of Medical College Kolkata. AFP

Runu Das, a local resident of the Chorbagan area, said that the injured were taken away on bikes, in taxis, and in cars belonging to local residents. "There were no policemen and there was no security. The organisers made wrong announcements and spread panic, which led to the stampede," she said.

Nibha Kumari, from Muzaffarpur in Bihar, lost her husband, Abhishek Srivastava, 38, and their 7-year-old son, Ayansh. Lying on a hospital bed in Kolkata, Kumari cried while regretting her decision to go pandal-hopping. "There were no policemen to help transport my husband and child to the hospital," she said.

The West Bengal government constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) led by Justice (retd.) Anindita Roy Saraswati to conduct an impartial and comprehensive inquiry into the tragedy. On October 22, five days after the crush, the chairperson and other members of the SIT visited the puja pandal. She pointed out that the lighting inside was woefully inadequate. "It goes without saying that the entrance and exit to the pandal are very narrow, and if a lot of people enter the pandal, an incident is bound to happen," she told mediapersons.

On the same day, the Kolkata Police arrested Sanjeev Raha, who had allegedly been responsible for making announcements at the pandal when the stampede broke out.

By October 23, they had arrested nine people in connection with a suo motu case registered at Girish Park police station. Those arrested and charged with culpable homicide not amounting to murder, among other offences, included Durga Puja committee secretary Raj Kumar Sewda (48), vice-president Santanu Dubey (55), and others responsible for the construction of the pandal's bamboo structure, crowd control and management, and private security.

The police did not take any of the senior BJP leaders named in the pandal's publicity material into custody.

A string of controversies

The Durga Puja celebrations were meant to be special for the BJP government, which had come to power in May this year with a two-thirds majority, ending the previous government's 15-year tenure. Chief Minister Adhikari repeatedly stated that the celebrations would follow tradition and the ritual calendar, accusing the previous government of violating religious practices. Adhikari said that the number of Durga Puja pandals across the State had increased by 25%, from 45,000 in 2025 to 57,400 in 2026.

However, the festival has been mired in controversy from the outset in 2026. Almost a month before the celebrations, Dhirendra Shastri, alias Bageshwar Baba, a godman from Madhya Pradesh, urged Bengalis to switch to a vegetarian diet during Durga Puja.

His remarks did not go down well in the State. A *bonedi bari* (aristocratic household) in north Kolkata's Sovabazar area said that its Durga Puja would continue according to traditions established by its ancestors, and that it would not abide by any diktats from "outsiders".

"She (Durga) is our Ma, our goddess. This is our tradition. Why would we listen to someone who does not belong to this tradition," asked Prabir Krishna Deb, an eighth-generation descendant of Raja Naba Krishna Deb, who started the Sobhabazar Rajbari pujas.

Deb belongs to the *choto torof* (younger branch) of the family, whose pujas began in 1790. He added that while some of their offerings to the goddess are vegetarian, the family eats mutton and fish during the festivities.

The widespread anger against Shastri's remarks prompted the BJP leadership, including the Chief Minister, to publicly consume a fish offering to convey the message that no one could lecture Bengalis on their dietary preferences.

A few weeks ago, the city's flyovers were painted in rainbow colours as part of the Durga Puja beautification drive. Urban Development Minister Agnimitra Paul, who oversaw the painting, had described it as a symbol of brotherhood and love. However, when motorcyclists began skidding on them, the administration went into damage-control mode, attempting to scrub off the paint and install cat's-eye reflectors. Paul said, "The paint that was used was supposed to be anti-skid paint. But since a few bikes still skid, we are now removing the paint. We are also probing how the accidents took place."

The Durga Puja festivities were also marked by attacks on temporary book stalls set up by Left parties at puja pandals. The Left parties have a tradition of setting up book stalls at the pandals, even though their supporters do not participate in the ritual aspects of Durga Puja. While State BJP president Samik Bhattacharya and Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta denounced the attacks on the stalls, Chief Minister Adhikari said that Left parties did not believe in Durga Puja or any other Hindu festival and had no business setting up book stalls at the pandals.

However, no controversy cast as long a shadow over Durga Puja in 2026 as the Chorbagan stampede. Celebrations were cancelled at the Chorbagan pandal, where the tragedy took place, and the site and pandal came under investigation. Adhikari visited the families of each of the deceased and handed them compensation cheques of ₹25 lakh.

When tragedy struck the north Kolkata puja pandal, Adhikari and senior BJP leaders were receiving Union Home Minister Amit Shah, who had several festival-related events lined up for October 18. Shah had to cancel his plans and return to Delhi that day after meeting the injured. The Chief Minister continued to emphasise how, unlike the previous government, his government had extended all possible support to those caught up in the stampede. Yet, the prevailing sentiment after the tragedy was that the State had never witnessed such a high number of casualties in a stampede during Durga Puja.

"This is a complete administrative failure," said Suman Roy Chaudhuri, a senior Congress leader. "As a north Kolkata resident, I can tell you that there were hardly any police personnel on the ground. This is a sorrow-filled puja. History will remember this."

No joy left

Durga Puja is the most auspicious time of the year for Bengalis, and deaths during the festivities have left people across the State heartbroken. One of the most iconic depictions of the loss of a loved one around the time of the festival is the death of young Durga in Satyajit Ray's classic *Pather Panchali,* shortly before Durga Puja.

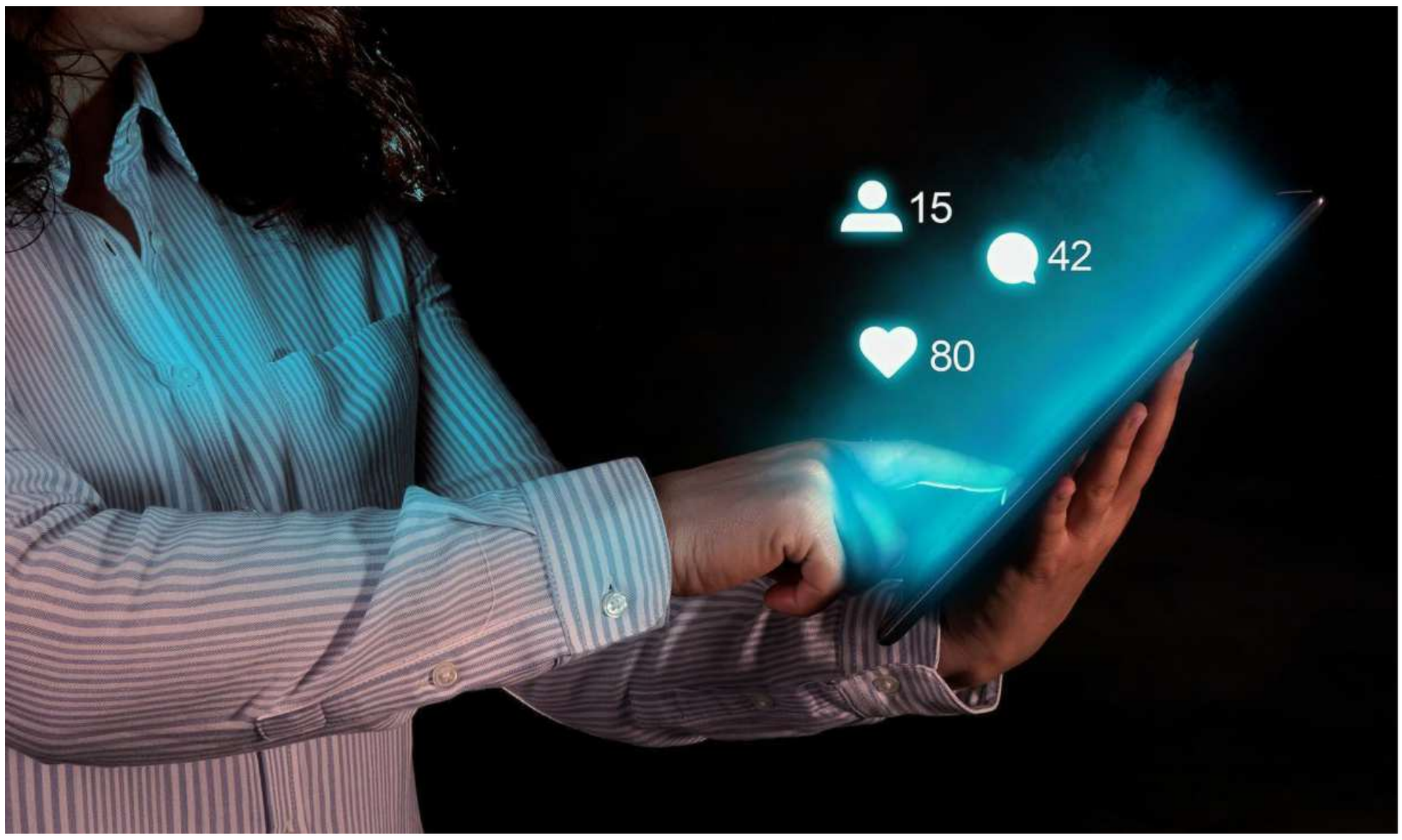
From the morning of October 18, relatives of the deceased began queuing up outside the Kolkata Police mortuary, behind another famous Durga Puja pandal at Mohammad Ali Park. A government official called out the names of the deceased, matching them with the serial numbers on the hearse vans as the bodies were loaded.

People looked on, shaking their heads in disbelief. Tears rolled down their cheeks. Amid the smell of the bodies, the strong scent of incense sticks hung heavy in the air.

"We are all in mourning. There is no joy left in Durga Puja," a bystander said at the morgue.

At Medical College Kolkata, Biswajit Biswas, the father of Tamina Biswas, 18, still cannot believe that his daughter is dead. With his wife by his side, he said, "How will we survive after this? There will be no Durga Puja for us ever again."

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According to a senior intelligence officer, digital honey-trapping served as the primary hook.ISTOCK GETTY IMAGES

How India thwarted Pakistan's bid to steal crucial defence data

Officers of the Counter Intelligence Cell of Andhra Pradesh, intrigued by a slew of messaging patterns across various social media platforms, busted a major digital honey-trap racket, including the Indian conduits, whose motive was to leak sensitive defence details, specifically Naval intelligence, to the neighbouring country's Inter-Services Intelligence, writes **Sumit Bhattacharjee**

About six months ago, a team of officers in Andhra Pradesh's Counter Intelligence Cell (CIC) noticed an unusual pattern of messaging across various social media platforms, including interactive messaging applications such as WhatsApp.

What intrigued the officers was an abnormal frequency of incoming and outgoing international communications. The communication pattern was immediately red-flagged. The CIC team alerted central intelligence agencies and leveraged the resources of NATGRID (National Intelligence Grid) and CMS (Central Monitoring System) core components of India's security infrastructure designed to combat terrorism, espionage, and cross-border threats - to trace Internet Protocol (IP) logs and WhatsApp One-Time Password (OTP) sharing patterns.

This initial anomaly marked the beginning of unearthing a far larger conspiracy and espionage racket involving the leaks of sensitive defence details - specifically Naval intelligence - by Indian conduits to their handlers in Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI).

After placing the subjects under close surveillance for several months, a dedicated team of officers and personnel from Andhra Pradesh's CIC, in close coordination with Naval Intelligence and Anti-Terrorist Squads (ATS) across 10 States, busted a major Pakistan-sponsored espionage network..

Code-naming the crackdown as 'Operation Firewall-2026', law enforcement agencies moved in to execute arrests. In the process, investigators identified 18 key suspects, including 13 Naval personnel spread across 10 States.

The operation has so far led to the arrest of two persons. Among them is Pradeep Mukherjee, a sailor in the Indian Navy posted at the Eastern Naval Command (ENC), who was taken into custody from INS Agrani in Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu, where he was undergoing training. Another person took into custody, identified as Annam Sai Varaprasad, is a civilian contract driver engaged for Naval officers at the Visakhapatnam naval base.

Although the coordinated operation was formally launched on October 1, the Andhra Pradesh CIC announced the arrests on October 5 and 6. The CIC stated that cases were registered under multiple provisions, including Section 61 (2) (criminal conspiracy) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Sections 17 and 18 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), 1967, Section 3 of the Official Secrets Act (OSA), 1923, along with other relevant sections of the BNS.

Mechanics of the espionage network

According to sources within Counter Intelligence, the operation followed a pattern typical of cross-border espionage. Pakistani Intelligence Operatives (PIOs) from the ISI identified vulnerabilities among potential targets, cultivating them to serve as assets within India.

The handlers deployed time-tested Vulnerability Mapping and the classic MICE (Money, Ideology, Coercion, and Extortion) framework to initiate contact, cultivate trust, and extract actionable information through digital honey-trapping combined with financial inducements. "That is precisely why they consistently target sailors or lower-ranking personnel in the Navy - individuals who may be facing financial distress and need money," noted a senior intelligence official.

> There are various sophisticated avenues of intelligence gathering today. Yet, field-level human intelligence remains one of the oldest and most reliable methods, and honey trapping is the oldest trick in the operational handbook. It happened decades ago, and it will continue to occur
> A senior Naval officer

In this instance, the operatives relied heavily on Social Engineering and open-source intelligence (OSINT) techniques. Handlers systematically scanned social media platforms to identify vulnerable defence personnel, government contractors, or civil servants before setting their traps.

According to a senior intelligence officer, digital honey-trapping served as the primary hook.

In such operations, fake female personas are engineered to initiate casual contact. Over time, these interactions graduate into romantic conversations, eventually leading to the exchange of sexually explicit content. While the investigation remains ongoing, preliminary findings confirm that explicit material was exchanged. However, investigators are still verifying whether the materials were subsequently used as leverage to blackmail and extract classified operational information.

Thus far, the investigation revealed that two trained female PIOs operating under the pseudonyms Joshita Pall and Anvi Mehta were in direct contact with the two arrested persons.

While "Joshita" claimed to be an employee at a shipbuilding firm in Mumbai, "Anvi" posed as a Delhi-based psychologist. The operatives initially established contact through Facebook before coaxing the targets to transition their conversations to WhatsApp.

Technical intelligence gathered by investigators indicates that the operatives approached defence personnel using fictitious social media profiles. Once rapport and trust were established, conversations rapidly shifted to text messaging, encrypted voice calls, and video calls. The broader strategy relied on fabricated professional identities, promises of romantic relationships, explicit adult content (including compromising video recordings), and monetary incentives paid via cryptocurrency channels.

According to a serving commander-rank officer, he had once received such unsolicited e-mail from a "very attractive-looking woman", who posed as an executive in a communication company. But after a very mundane conversation, I could understand that it was a honey trap, as she sounded very keen to know about my rank, my postings and other confidential details. I broke the contact immediately. Later, I realised that she had picked up my profile from a matrimonial site, as at that time my parents and I were browsing through such sites. They look for vulnerabilities and target their needs and aspirations, he said.

A CIC official explained that initial conversations are typically mundane and centre on trivial matters. However, trained operatives gradually steer discussions toward sensitive operational domains, extracting fragments of information. They then connect these disparate data points to reconstruct operational theories or draft comprehensive intelligence briefs. In the current case, investigators allege that the ultimate objective was to persuade personnel to share classified defence intelligence.

The operatives reportedly sought intelligence regarding: movements and schedules of Naval vessels and submarines. Photographs and video footage of naval assets and sensitive installations. The identities, routines, and movements of Commanding Officers. Live operational tours during video calls, where personnel were urged to show sensitive areas of naval bases, ships, and submarines.

It is now established that the names and profiles of these PIOs were completely fraudulent, with strong indicators suggesting they may have been generated using Artificial Intelligence (AI). It is a recognised reality in modern counter-espionage that foreign intelligence agencies, including Pakistan's ISI, rely heavily on generative AI and deepfake technologies to conduct digital honey-trap operations.

Handlers use generative AI models to construct hyper-realistic human faces, photo galleries, and video clips that do not exist anywhere else on the open web, frequently leaving cyber-investigators without initial reference points.

> We have initiated deep digital forensic recovery procedures to retrieve deleted chat histories, transmitted image files, and underlying metadata
> A CIC official

Profile cloning, deepfakes, and real-time AI voice-swapping calibrated to match local accents are the latest weapons in the intelligence arena. Generative AI models can mimic regional dialects and cultural nuances, making conversations feel remarkably natural. Intelligence sources confirm that this specific technological dimension of the case remains under active investigation.

Why the focus remains on Vizag?

Pakistani intelligence has long maintained a focused interest in the ENC based in Visakhapatnam. Historically, during the 1971 Indo-Pakistani War, Pakistan deployed its most advanced submarine, the PNS Ghazi, to the waters off Visakhapatnam with the specific objective of tracking and sinking India's aircraft carrier, INS Vikrant.

Visakhapatnam is not merely home to one of India's largest Naval bases; it serves as the home port for the Arihant-class nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarines (SSBNs). These assets operate under the Strategic Forces Command (SFC) and represent a vital leg of India's nuclear triad. Furthermore, the highly classified Ship Building Centre (SBC), where these nuclear submarines are constructed and fitted out, is located within this naval enclave.

Ever since India commissioned its first indigenous SSBN INS Arihant, foreign intelligence agencies have intensified efforts to gather granular details regarding the facility and its assets.

This operation is far from the first cross-border espionage case targeting the ENC.

In December 2019, Operation Dolphin's Nose exposed an extensive spying network targeting the ENC. That investigation uncovered a network of Pakistani Intelligence Operatives who utilised digital honey-traps, hawala money channels, and local conduits to compromise junior naval personnel.

Initially detected and investigated by the Andhra Pradesh CIC, the 2019 case was subsequently handed over to the National Investigation Agency (NIA). Approximately 15 people, including seven Naval personnel, were arrested, establishing direct links to the ISI. The NIA has since secured formal convictions against several of the key accused.

The operational methodology and the nature of intelligence sought in the current case bear striking similarities to the 2019 enterprise: detailed data on ship and submarine deployments, dockyard layouts, and base logistics.

In both instances, suspects were charged under stringent legislation, including the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), Section 3 of the Official Secrets Act (OSA), and Section 120B of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) for criminal conspiracy.

"There are various sophisticated avenues of intelligence gathering today, including high-resolution satellite imagery. Yet, field-level human intelligence remains one of the oldest and most reliable methods, and honey-trapping is the oldest trick in the operational handbook. It happened decades ago, and it will continue to occur," observed a senior Naval officer.

The painstaking probe

Narrowing down the suspects in "Operation Firewall, 2026" required months of painstaking investigation. Once anomalous international messaging traffic was flagged, the AP CIC and central intelligence agencies deployed technical surveillance frameworks like NATGRID and CMS to intercept incoming and outgoing international communications, trace IP logs, monitor WhatsApp OTP sharing patterns, and isolate digital channels used to exfiltrate classified naval data. High-end decryption tools were used to decipher end-to-end encrypted messages.

Investigative sources confirmed that financial transactions and the real-world identities of the suspects were mapped using NATGRID databases. Money trails involving suspicious bank transfers, local hawala networks, and cryptocurrency micro-payments were traced across 10 Indian states.

A critical breakthrough occurred when investigators uncovered a local support architecture that utilised Indian SIM cards registered under fictitious or stolen local names. These local conduits shared One-Time Passwords (OTPs) with foreign handlers overseas. Indian intermediaries were enticed with monetary incentives - paid either in cryptocurrency or through local cash transfers - to supply the OTPs required to activate fresh WhatsApp accounts. Once activated, these messaging accounts were operated remotely from Pakistan by ISI handlers.

However, capturing digital footprints was insufficient to secure convictions.

"After conducting extensive digital surveillance, we immediately moved to gather simultaneous human intelligence (HumInt). It required months of synthesising both TechInt and HumInt before we possessed sufficient operational proof to execute the raids," explained a CIC official.

A senior IPS officer involved in the operation detailed the complexity of counter-espionage investigations:

"Because this is an active national security investigation, full operational details cannot be disclosed. However, in cases of this magnitude, putting targets under surveillance and compiling actionable counter-intelligence takes months or even years. We utilise specialised methodologies, including launching proxy sites to entrap rogue actors.

While our technical capabilities operate within specific framework constraints compared to agencies in the US, Israel, or Russia, we routinely collaborate with partner nations to verify cross-border intelligence. The most challenging aspect remains retrieving encrypted message logs from foreign application developers and service providers, as they operate under strict user privacy contracts. Recovering data from platforms using end-to-end encryption requires demonstrating explicit national security threats to obtain high-level judicial and administrative authorisation, a process that can take weeks or months."

Safeguards and operational security

In light of evolving cyber threats and cross-border espionage networks, the Ministry of Defence has instituted stringent operational security (OPSEC) frameworks across all service branches to safeguard classified assets.

Despite these protocols, the key question remains: How do foreign operatives continue to breach security perimeters, and how do compromised assets successfully transmit classified operational data?

The Armed Forces, including the Indian Navy, have banned a wide array of high-risk commercial applications and imposed strict regulations on Virtual Private Networks (VPNs). Personnel are explicitly prohibited from using social networking platforms, online gaming chat servers, or commercial VPN applications on both official and personal devices while stationed at sensitive bases or operational commands.

Despite these prohibitions, preliminary findings indicate that photographs and video recordings of sensitive military installations were successfully transmitted by the accused to their overseas handlers.

Military regulations mandate a strict "zero-tolerance" policy regarding unreported contact with unknown or suspicious foreign social media profiles. Service personnel undergo continuous training to identify and report suspected "honey-pot" solicitation attempts immediately.

Prompt reporting allows counter-intelligence units to initiate immediate "trap-and-trace" operations or feed coordinated disinformation back to foreign intelligence handlers.

While the CIC and collaborating intelligence agencies have conducted digital forensic audits on seized mobile phones, hard drives, and communication hardware confiscated from Naval bases and private residences, officials have not yet disclosed the full extent of the classified material that was exfiltrated.

"We have initiated deep digital forensic recovery procedures to retrieve deleted chat histories, transmitted image files, and underlying metadata," stated a CIC official. While 18 primary suspects have been formally identified and two individuals are currently in custody, additional arrests and detailed disclosures are anticipated in the coming days as forensic analysis proceeds.



Telangana's population aged 60 and above is projected to rise from 12.5% in 2026 to 17.1% in 2036, as per an RBI report. The projection raises questions about how healthcare, caregiving and community support can keep pace with the needs of older people. REPRESENTATIONAL PHOTO

A greying population, a strained care system

Gaps in geriatric healthcare and support systems leave many older people struggling to access medical care, find reliable caregivers, and cope with mental health concerns and social isolation. These challenges threaten their independence and quality of life, particularly among those from economically weaker backgrounds. With Telangana's population aged 60 and above projected to grow over the next decade, the shortcomings in healthcare, mental health support, and community services need urgent attention, finds **K. Shiva Shanker**

Girija (name changed) spent years working as a domestic worker before her failing knees made it difficult for her to continue. Hoping to find a more manageable way to earn a living, the 60-year-old borrowed money from acquaintances and set up a roadside vegetable stall. But another health problem emerged, making it difficult to keep the business running.

"She learnt that she was suffering from urinary incontinence. Taking frequent loo breaks while managing the stall was not practical, and she eventually decided to shut shop, losing her source of income in the process," says Gurajada Sobha Pernidevi, founder-president of Telangana Stree Seva Samstha, a voluntary organisation working for the welfare of women.

For older people with limited financial means, a health problem can do more than cause physical discomfort; it can take away their livelihood, independence and opportunities to socialise. Conditions that are difficult to discuss, such as urinary incontinence, are often endured in silence because of embarrassment and the cost of managing them.

Unlike ailments that call for joint replacement surgery or a cardiac stent, these less visible difficulties of ageing often receive scant attention, despite their potential to disrupt daily life. However, as Telangana's share of elderly population grows, addressing such overlooked needs will become increasingly important.

Telangana's population aged 60 and above is projected to rise from 12.5% in 2026 to 17.1% in 2036, according to the Reserve Bank of India's report, 'State Finances – A Study of Budgets of 2025-26: Demographic Transition in India – Implications for State Finances'.

The State is expected to join the category of ageing ones, where senior citizens account for at least 15% of the population. The projected demographic shift raises questions about how healthcare, caregiving and community support can keep pace with the needs of older people, particularly those who live alone or cannot afford private services.

Associations working with senior citizens say the challenges range from obtaining medicines and reaching hospitals to finding dependable caregivers and accessing mental health support.

P. Shyam Kumar, State project coordinator at HelpAge India, says doorstep medical services, including palliative care, could make healthcare more accessible. Nutritional supplements and the delivery of medicines through Accredited Social Health Activists could also help older people manage their health.

"Without adequate support, their condition may deteriorate, leading to more hospital visits, additional expenses and greater dependence on family members. So, supplying medicines through Accredited Social Health Activists may work in this direction," he adds.

The pace mismatch

Access to healthcare is not simply a matter of getting an appointment or obtaining medicines. Older people who depend on younger family members for hospital visits may have to wait until someone can take time off work and accompany them.

> While physiological issues get attention, mental health issues in old age are barely discussed. One should not dismiss every problem as an inevitable part of ageing. It is important to consult the relevant medical specialists.
>
> **AARATHI BELLARY,** Physician

Members of several associations say a family member's availability often influences whether and when an older person seeks medical attention. Those with limited mobility may need transport, a wheelchair or stretcher. In a multi-storey building without a suitable lift, even getting someone downstairs can require additional assistance and planning. Hospital visits can involve long walks between departments, diagnostic tests and consultations, making them particularly difficult for those without someone to accompany them.

The problem does not end at the hospital gate. For older people who cannot leave home, finding a doctor willing to make a home visit can be equally difficult. "This is a crucial requirement of those who are unable to step out of their house," says Sobha.

For older couples whose children have moved away for work, one partner falling ill can leave the other struggling to coordinate treatment, travel and follow-up visits. The absence of accessible transport and medical services at home can turn routine healthcare into an exhausting exercise.

Shanti, trustee and volunteer at Roshni Trust, which has organised mental health camps in *bastis*, says Hyderabad's urban spaces do little to encourage inclusion and social interaction among older people. "The city is designed for isolation and does not promote inclusiveness," she says.

Shanti calls for government centres at the basti level, on the lines of Anganwadis, where older people can access basic facilities, attend health camps and receive nutritious food. Such centres could also offer a place to meet others, reducing isolation among those who spend much of their time at home.

The search for dependable care

For older people who need help with daily activities, finding a caregiver presents its own difficulties. Volunteers point to the need for people who understand the physical and emotional needs of senior citizens, as well as concerns about safety when elderly couples live alone and their children live elsewhere. Sobha recalls the case of an elderly woman who sleeps during the day and stays awake at night to keep an eye on her caregiver, fearing for her safety.

"This fear weighs on many older people who live with hired help," she adds.

Through Telangana Stree Seva Samstha, she along with 80-plus volunteers, distributes adult diapers, commode converter seats, walking sticks, books and other resources to those who need them.

S. Bhooma Reddy (78), editor of *Voice of Senior Citizens* magazine, says the demand for caregivers is substantial, with some families hiring them even when their children live in the same building. "The caregivers are paid a monthly salary of around ₹25,000, apart from being provided food and accommodation," he adds.

Such arrangements, however, remain beyond the reach of many households. Families from financially disadvantaged backgrounds often live in cramped homes and juggle work, household responsibilities and the care of parents or in-laws with limited resources.

V. Manjula, president of Gruha Karmikula Union-Telangana, says opening community halls where older people are provided regular meals and medicines would be a significant source of support for those from poor backgrounds.

The consequences of inadequate family support can be more severe than the absence of daily assistance. Associations report cases of older people being abandoned at hospitals, railway stations and bus stops. They also cite instances of elderly parents being neglected after transferring property to their children. Physical ailments are not the only problems that can go unnoticed as people grow older. Depression and dementia, too, may remain undiagnosed because their early signs are mistaken for normal aspects of ageing.

> Social and aspirational security has to be factored in while designing spaces for the elderly, to meet their emotional and intellectual aspirations. This has to be planned for people of all financial segments.
>
> **AMBATI RAMPAPA RAO,** Chairman, PACCS Healthcare

K. Chandra Sekhar, 70, founder-director of ASHA Hospitals, says families often seek specialist help only after symptoms have worsened. Forgetfulness, which can be an early sign of dementia, is frequently dismissed as a natural consequence of growing old. Such assumptions can delay diagnosis and prevent older people and their families from accessing appropriate support.

"Early diagnosis can improve quality of life and help caregivers prepare for the support that may be required as a condition progresses," he says.

A loss of interest in activities once enjoyed, reduced appetite and weight loss, less social interaction and multiple physical complaints can be signs of depression, Dr. Chandra Sekhar points out. Older people experiencing forgetfulness can consult neurologists or psychiatrists.

While health camps often screen for physical illnesses, camps focused on identifying mental health problems are rarely organised, he says.

Aarathi Bellary, consultant physician and co-founder of Aayu Geriatrics, says some older people overlook age-related health problems even when symptoms become apparent.

"While physiological issues get attention, mental health issues in old age are barely discussed. One should not dismiss every problem as an inevitable part of ageing. It is important to consult the relevant medical specialists," she says.

Dr. Bellary also encourages older people to pursue hobbies, maintain an active social life and take part in activities that allow them to share their knowledge and experience. Such engagement can help them remain socially connected rather than being defined solely by their health needs.

Planning for assisted living

For those who need more sustained support, assisted living and other residential care options could fill a gap between hospital treatment and independent living. Hyderabad, however, has only a few such facilities.

Ambati Rampapa Rao, chairman of PACCS Healthcare Pvt Ltd, which has a subsidiary, Ucchvas Transitional Care Centres, says longer life expectancy has made it necessary to plan for the changing needs of older people, particularly when their children move out of their hometown.

Ageing can bring a range of difficulties, including reduced physical strength, tremors, weight loss, malnutrition and emotional or psychological problems, affecting one's ability to carry out everyday activities.

Dr. Rao outlines three broad categories of elderly care. Transitional care provides support immediately after hospital discharge, ranging from a few weeks to several years, with some degree of medical supervision; assisted living caters to those whose age and medical history call for monitoring and preventive care; and elderly living facilities serve people who remain mobile but have minor health problems.

"Social and aspirational security has to be factored in while designing spaces for the elderly, to meet their emotional and intellectual aspirations. This has to be planned for people of all financial segments," he says.

With corporates exploring investments in the sector, the number of facilities could increase. But affordability remains central to whether these services can reach those who need them the most.

Care beyond the family

The Telangana government has sanctioned 37 multi-service daycare centres for senior citizens, of which 32 are operational. Run by non-governmental organisations with full financial support and monitoring from the government, the centres encourage social interaction and provide nutritious food, indoor games and basic medical check-ups once a week.

For older people who depend on regular meals or monitoring of health conditions, however, the reliability of these services matters as much as their availability. One elderly woman says she worries that health problems could jeopardise her access to the centre.

"My sugar levels shoot up if I don't have food on time. Someone else may develop other health problems. If we fall ill at the centre, our children may consider taking us there a hassle and ask us to stop going," she says.

Her concern points to a larger dilemma: services intended to support older people may not be enough if families view the time and effort involved in accessing them as a burden.

As Telangana's elderly population grows, the challenge will be to make care accessible not only to those who can afford paid assistance, but also to people whose health problems, limited mobility or financial circumstances threaten their independence.





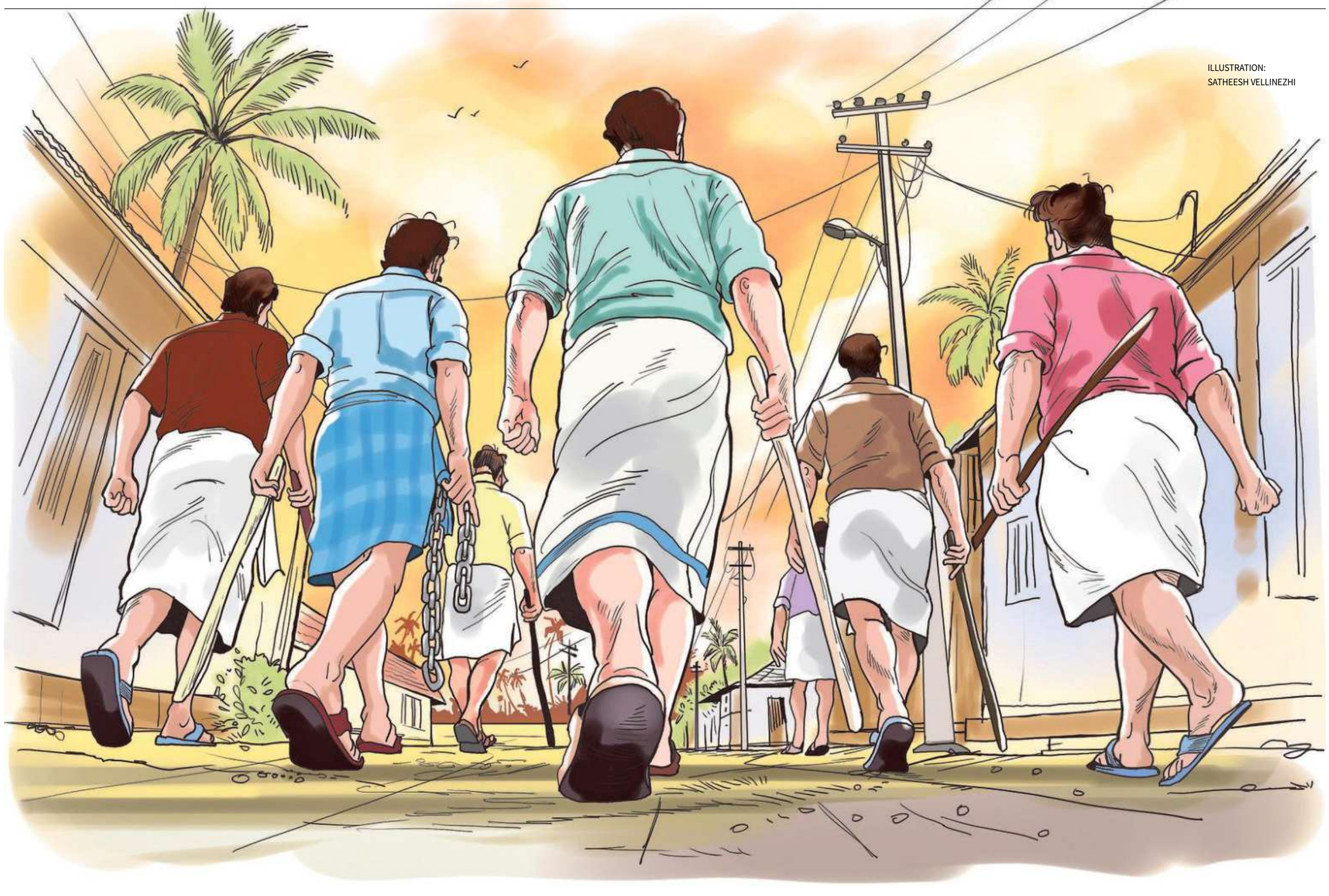


ILLUSTRATION: SATHEESH VELLINEZHI

Trial by mob

The brutal lynching of an aurally challenged, unidentified man near the Moolathara dam in Palakkad district of Keralam has once again shaken the conscience of society. **Abdul Latheef Naha** speaks to investigators, psychiatrists, and forensic experts to understand how a homeless man became the target of a group that took it upon itself to punish him and how such incidents recur

The flesh looked pounded.

Contusions piled upon contusions. As forensic surgeon Hithesh Sanker examined the battered body that was laid on the post-mortem table, suspicion gave way to a grim realisation—this was no ordinary death.

The man had been lynched.

He had no name. He could not speak. He could communicate only through sign language.

Found dead near the Moolathara dam in Palakkad recently, the man in his late 30s bore nearly 50 injuries.

He was allegedly stoned and beaten with sticks for sleeping outside a house at Nedumpara.

Whatever he had tried to communicate, no one had understood or cared to.

By October 11 morning, the man, yet unidentified, lay dead. There was no known prior enmity or established offence.

The police registered a case for unnatural death. The post-mortem examination at the Government Medical College Hospital, Thrissur, revealed the brutality of the crime.

Similar incidents

The killing echoes two other brutal lynching in the State—of Madhu, a tribesperson beaten to death in Attappady in 2018 over allegations of stealing food, and of Ram Narayan Baghel, a migrant worker from Chhattisgarh lynched at Walayar in December 2025 on suspicion of theft.

The pattern goes back even further. In 2010, Rajendran, a 34-year-old man described as mentally unstable, was tied to a post and beaten through the night at Peruvemba. He died, and eight accused were sentenced to life imprisonment.

Different men, different circumstances, but a chilling common thread—the vulnerable become targets, suspicion becomes a verdict, and a mob assumes the power to punish.

Seven people were booked in connection with the killing. Kathiresan, one of the accused, is alleged to have led the attack. The victim had reportedly been sleeping in front of his house.

There were no apparent eyewitnesses.

Confession

The confession of one accused became a crucial lead, while investigators collected other evidence, including fingerprints. A 10-member special investigation team led by Chittur Deputy Superintendent of Police (Dy.SP) M. Sasidharan is pursuing the case.

"We have extended the search to different parts along the border. We have published the photo of the victim in various groups, including that of ASHAs, SC/ST promoters and local body ward members. We have informed different settlements along the border, both in Keralam and Tamil Nadu," says Rajeesh S., Circle Inspector of Police, Kozhinjampara.

> Even the weakest person who has not beaten someone in his life may take part in lynching. That is mob psychology.
>
> **P.B. GUJRAL**
> Forensic expert and former police surgeon

The search for his identity continues, but the killing raises a larger question: how did a homeless man become the target of a group that took it upon itself to punish him?

Recurring pattern

The Moolathara lynching reflects a recurring pattern—suspicion becomes accusation, and a crowd assumes the authority to deliver punishment.

P. Premnath, former Deputy Director of Prosecution, says India has witnessed numerous cases of mob lynching and cow vigilantism over the past decade. Earlier, prosecutors relied on provisions of the Indian Penal Code covering murder, rioting and unlawful assembly, including Section 149, which holds members of an unlawful assembly liable for offences committed in pursuit of its common object.

The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), which came into force in July 2024, introduced Section 103(2), which provides for punishment for group murder on specified discriminatory grounds. "Its application depends on the circumstances of each case," explains Premnath.

In its 2018 judgment in Tehseen S. Poonawalla vs Union of India, the Supreme Court laid down measures to prevent and punish lynching, including designated police officers, speedy trials and victim compensation.

Yet such violence persists.

"Responsibility should be established through evidence, and those found guilty should face the consequences," says Premnath.

No suspicion or accusation gives a crowd the right to take the law into its own hands. "None has the right to hurt or take anyone's life," asserts Anees Ali, outgoing general secretary of the Indian Psychiatric Society's Keralam unit. "There is no right to try anyone publicly."

At Moolathara, the man may have been unwanted by those around him. He may have been unable to explain why he was there. Neither circumstance could justify violence.

Dayal Narayan, Head of the Department (HoD) of Psychiatry at Government Medical College Hospital, Manjeri, says aggression is a human instinct, but civilisation depends on learning to control it. "Humans, like animals, have an instinct for aggression. It manifests in different ways, from road rage to violence on sports fields," points out Dr. Narayan. Civilisation depends on learning to control these impulses, weigh consequences and resolve conflicts peacefully. But those restraints can fail, he notes.

"When people lose trust in social checks and balances, they take the law into their own hands. Some see it as heroism or an expression of solidarity; others believe they are serving a good cause. The aggressor becomes the hero," he observes.

> People should intervene sensibly when a confrontation threatens to escalate. Calling the police, seeking help and moving a vulnerable person to safety can prevent violence from becoming fatal.
>
> **DAYAL NARAYAN**
> HoD, Psychiatry, Government Medical College Hospital, Manjeri

Once an assault begins, others may join in or reinforce the violence rather than challenge it. The group emboldens individuals, weakening their sense of personal responsibility. "Instead of correcting an action, group members tend to reinforce it," notes Dr. Narayan.

Dr. Ali identifies personality, social conditioning and substance abuse as possible contributing factors. Alcohol impairs judgement and lowers inhibitions, while peer pressure and heightened emotions can further weaken restraint, he notes.

The prefrontal cortex, which governs judgement and impulse control, continues to mature into the mid-to-late twenties. But brain development alone cannot explain mob violence; social influences and individual choices also matter.

"Substance abuse is behind many crimes. Crimes due to substance abuse are increasing in the State," Dr. Ali observes.

Dr. Narayan cautions against assuming that everyone involved in a group attack has the same psychological profile. Participation in a crime alone cannot establish a psychiatric diagnosis.

Mob psychology

The question is how ordinary social restraints fail so completely that a group stops recognising the humanity of the person before it. Forensic evidence often reveals violence that a community may not have witnessed or acknowledged.

P.B. Gujral, veteran forensic expert and former police surgeon who helped develop the Kerala Medico-Legal Code, says lynching can cause injuries more extensive than those seen in many other forms of homicide. "All murders are cruel and painful. But lynching is worse than any other form of murder," he feels. Repeated blows from several people can cause extensive internal bleeding and damage to organs. Bruises accumulate, blood vessels rupture and injuries become fatal through their combined effect, say medical experts.

"They keep beating, piling injury upon injury," Dr. Gujral says.

He recalls cases of group assaults in which victims suffered more than 100 injuries. The damage inflicted by a crowd can far exceed what any one participant might have caused alone.

"Even the weakest person who has not beaten someone in his life may take part in lynching. That is mob psychology," Dr. Gujral says.

Dr. Sanker questions a society that fails to protect the vulnerable. "If literacy does not make us more humane, what purpose does it serve?" he wonders.

"A mob has no authority to administer punishment. Suspicion is not a crime, and an accusation is not a conviction," he says. The victim's inability to communicate or defend himself should have invited help, not violence. "Even though we do not know his name, we have a moral obligation to demand justice on his behalf."

Proving the crime

Dr. Gujral notes that parts of Palakkad have witnessed repeated mass assaults in the past. Forensic evidence alone, however, cannot secure a conviction. "For a crime to be proven and convicted, it requires the cooperation of society," he says.

Witnesses must speak, evidence should be preserved, and communities must resist pressure to protect those accused of violence. Fear and silence can weaken an investigation even when physical evidence is compelling, he feels.

Soumya P., a social worker from Chittur, calls the lynching a shame on the region. "Nobody knew such a brutal killing had taken place until the post-mortem revealed it," she says. The attack, carried out at night in an isolated spot, went unseen by residents, she says.

People sleeping outdoors often remain outside the attention of families, neighbours and public services. Their isolation makes them harder to be protected.

Dr. Narayan says people should intervene sensibly when a confrontation threatens to escalate. Calling the police, seeking help and moving a vulnerable person to safety can prevent violence from becoming fatal.

"We need such people," he says, referring to those willing to act when violence begins. Yet people too often walk away.

He also calls for sustained protection for people living on the streets, noting that efforts made during the COVID-19 lockdown should not disappear when an emergency ends.

Dr. Ali argues that awareness should reach young people and families. Dr. Narayan calls for cultural change beginning in childhood, when respect for others should be taught through everyday behaviour, not merely textbooks and slogans. Dr. Gujral stresses speedy trials and public awareness.

Though homeless and unable to make himself understood, the Moolathara lynching victim needed help, not hostility. His name remains unknown, yet his right to live was never in doubt.

INBRIEF



BPCL Q2 net profit falls 22.5% amid volatile crude prices

Bharat Petroleum's standalone net profit in the September-ended quarter fell 22.5% on a year-on-year basis as volatile crude following the reignited conflict in West Asia prices impacted margins. The Mumbai-headquartered refiner's net profit declined to ₹4,993.17 crore in the quarter compared with ₹6,442.5 crore in the same period last year. The State-owned oil company's cost of materials consumed soared 44.2% during the period to ₹74,969 crore.

IndusInd Bank posts net profit of ₹1,242 crore in Q2

IndusInd Bank Limited posted a net profit of ₹1,242 crore for the quarter ended September, up 20% sequentially, and trimming net loss of ₹437 crore for the same quarter of the preceding year. The bank had incurred net loss for the same period in previous year due to an increase in microfinance provisioning and write-offs. The bank's bottom line for Q2 FY27 was supported by a rise in net interest income, which stood at ₹4,569 crore as against ₹4,409 crore a year ago.

Dr. Reddy's Q2 net falls 32% to ₹913 cr. on lower revenue

Dr. Reddy's Laboratories reported September quarter consolidated net profit declined more than 31% to ₹913.2 crore compared with ₹1,336.8 crore a year earlier on lower global generics revenue, particularly a sharp dip in the mainstay North America market. Revenue from operations for the Hyderabad-based multinational stood at ₹8,697.8 crore, down from ₹8,828.3 crore a year earlier, according to results prepared under Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS).

Oil prices extend rally to a near six-month high

Brent crude futures touched intra-day high of $117 a barrel on Friday, a day after Houthi attacks on Saudi's civilian and energy infra; India's crude basket has averaged $120.08 so far this month

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Oil prices extended their rally from Thursday, inching closer to a six-month high and the $120 per barrel-mark, a day after the Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia's civilian and energy infrastructure.

The latest attacks have renewed tensions over disruptions to global oil supplies. At the time of writing this report on Friday evening, benchmark Brent crude futures for December delivery had accelerated about 3.8% from its previous close to an intra-day high of $117.42 per barrel.

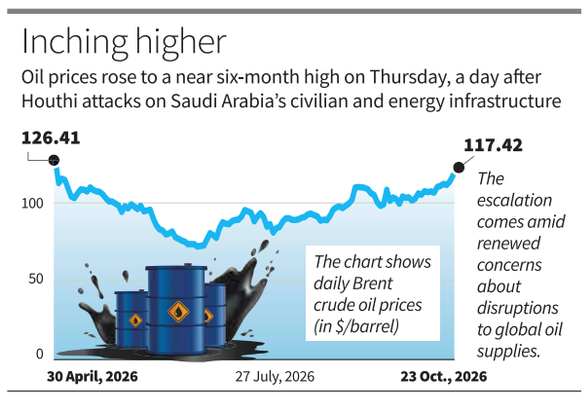
West Texas Intermediate (WTI) was also up 3.64% at $103.09 per barrel. India's crude oil basket averaged $119.99 per barrel on Friday, according to data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC). The Indian basket has averaged $120.08 per barrel till date in the ongoing month.

The latest benchmark prices are much higher than the Reserve Bank of India's projections of crude oil prices being at $95 per barrel in the second half of the fiscal year.

An increase in crude oil prices elevates concerns of persisting inflation.

According to estimates by Vipul Jindal and Tanay Dalal, economists at private sector lender Axis Bank, public sector support of approximately 1.7% of GDP would cushion shocks when average oil prices stay at $100 per barrel this year.

"Every $10 per barrel increase in crude [but pump prices steady], will raise support by 20 bps," the economists estimate.



Adani raises CNG prices

Amid higher input gas pressures, Adani Total Gas on Friday increased the prices of compressed natural gas (CNG) at its retail stations by ₹4.45 per kg.

CNG at its outlets in Gujarat's Ahmedabad is now priced at ₹98.47 per kg, ₹102.6 per kg in Haryana's Faridabad and ₹106.4 per kg in Rajasthan's Udaipur.

On a standalone basis, the company operates 723 refuelling outlets across the country.

'Crude oil sourcing volatile at present'

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI


Vikas Kaushal

Crude oil sourcing at present is highly volatile and unpredictable, and HPCL is procuring more on a delivered basis than on free-on-board (FOB) and term contracts, Vikas Kaushal, Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of the State-owned oil-marketing company told analysts in an investor call on Friday.

Purchases on delivered basis entail the seller to bear the shipping cost and associated risks until it reaches the buyer's port or facility.

"All I can say if you look at crude premiums and landed cost: there are times when there are premiums and there are times when you can even pick it up at discounts. It is a very 'Wild West' right now," Mr. Kaushal said.

He also said that there could be instances where discounts exist though freight cost is very high.

Srividya Venkataraman, Director (Finance), informed analysts that freight costs had doubled between the first and the second quarter.

She observed that shipping costs on a Suezmax tanker went up to $9 per barrel in Q2FY27, from about $4 per barrel in June.

Mr. Kaushal also stated that the landed price may not be as high as it might appear. Ms. Venkataraman informed that under-recoveries on LPG stood at ₹245 per cylinder in October and is projected at ₹327 per cylinder in November.

'Informed customers of data breach individually'

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

State Bank of India on Friday said that it had informed all customers individually regarding the recent data breach through email and/or WhatsApp.

The country's largest commercial bank had come under criticism for not informing affected customers, though it intimated the incident to stock exchanges. In a statement, the SBI said "We reiterate that your account balances and funds are safe with us."

"Customers are advised to follow safe digital banking practices, never share their OTP, PIN or password with anyone, and remain vigilant against suspicious calls, messages and emails," it stated.

Markets snap one-week rally following surge in crude prices, FII outflows

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Indian markets snapped the one-week rally on Friday, with most indices ending in the red following a surge in crude prices and foreign fund outflows.

The 30-share BSE Sensex fell more than 1% during the day before settling at 73,123.83, down 125.56 points from its previous close. Nifty declined to the 22,400-level before unwinding some losses, and ended at 22,600, down 87.65 points, or 0.4%.

"Benchmark indices closed in negative territory as elevated Brent crude oil prices and weak global cues continued to weigh on investor sentiment. Selling pressure remained broad-based, with the broader market witnessing a sharper decline than the frontline indices," Pabitro Mukherjee, deputy VP – Research, Bajaj Broking, said in a note.

Brent crude prices hit a near six-month high of $117.42 per barrel after the Houthi attacks in Saudi Arabia. Heightened worries over geopolitical tensions continue to fuel risk-averse sentiments toward emerging market economies among global investors. Foreign institutional investors remain net sellers in Indian equities.

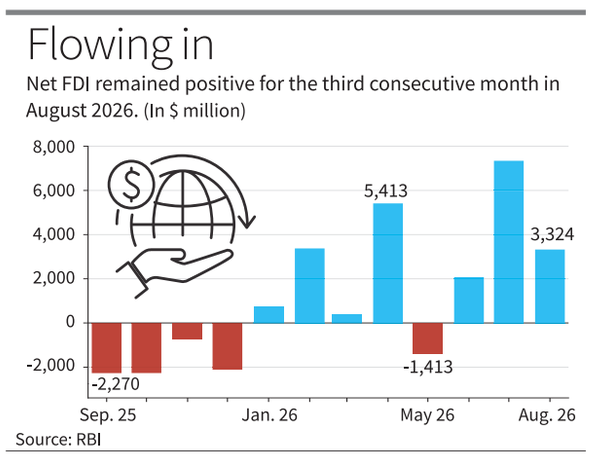
They withdrew ₹3,459 crore from the bourses on Thursday, though IPO-linked flows and domestic institutional buyers offset the sustained outflow.

Net FDI at $3.3 bn in August, stayed positive for third consecutive month: RBI bulletin

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Net foreign direct investment (FDI) was positive for the third consecutive month in August with inflows exceeding outflows by $3.3 billion, as per latest data from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). This was driven by robust inflows even as outward investments by Indian companies slid.

"FDI flows continued to remain robust in August supported by strong gross inflows and moderation in outward FDI," the RBI said in its monthly Bulletin. "Communication, miscellaneous services and manufacturing received more than two-thirds of the FDI inflows."



Net FDI, which is the difference between the total direct investment coming in and the total going out, was positive in seven out of the last eight months. This is a significant turnaround from the five consecutive months of negative net FDI India saw during August-December 2025.

Money flowing in

The data shows that gross FDI into India, or the total that entered the country as direct investment stood at $11.1 billion in August, which was 24% lower than in the previous month but almost 68% higher than in August last year. "The U.S., Singapore and Mauritius were the major source countries, accounting for about 72% of FDI inflows."

Total outflows rose a tad to $7.7 billion in August vis a vis $7.2 billion in July and $6.7 billion in August 2025. However, in this, the driver was the repatriation by foreign firms operating in India than outward investment by Indian firms.

Less investment outflow

"Outward FDI flows moderated in August with more than half being directed towards Singapore, the Netherlands, and the U.S," the RBI said. "The major sectors of outward FDI were agriculture & mining, financial, insurance & business services, and manufacturing accounting for more than two-thirds of the outward flows."

Remittances rose to $5.8 billion in August or almost 52% higher than in July, and 28% higher than in August 2025. This was largely balanced out by a fall in outward FDI to $1.9 billion. This was over 43% lower than in July and 11% lower than in August 2025.

In the longer time-period of April-August, gross and net FDI flows were higher. A slowdown in the pace of outward FDI with sustained higher gross FDI inflow supported net FDI flows," the RBI said.

'Broad-based food price increase seen'

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

High-frequency data collated by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) for October (till 19th), suggest broad-based rise in food prices, said RBI officials in the October edition of RBI Bulletin.

"Among cereals, rice and wheat prices continued to rise. Prices of major pulses also went up sequentially. Edible oil prices also recorded a slow and broad-based increase, led by mustard and palm oil," they wrote in the 'State of the Economy' article.

Among vegetables, potato prices slid while pace of onion price rise dipped. Tomato prices rose.

Surprisingly, inflation in rural areas has been rising more than in urban areas.


Rice and wheat prices continued to increase.

While inflation stood at 4.9% and 6.1% respectively, in urban and rural areas in September against 4.3% and 5.2% in August.

Stating WPI inflation logged its first double-digit rate in the new series (Base 2022-23) at 11.4% in September from 9.9% in August reflecting a broad-based price rise, they said industrial and farm input costs remained elevated.

Tata Motors turns Q2 net profit of ₹1,257 crore

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Tata Motors Ltd, the commercial vehicles firm of the Tata Group, for the second quarter ended September 30 reported consolidated net profit of ₹1,257 crore against net loss of ₹867 crore a year earlier.

The turnaround was led by lower mark-to-market loss on investments in Tata Capital Ltd. Consolidated revenue rose 36% to ₹25,232 crore. The firm said it was going ahead with Iveco acquisition as planned and raised the offer price to €14.4, up €30 cents, to compensate shareholders for the 4-month delay in getting regulatory approvals for the deal.

'Panama a Latam base for T.N. firms'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The unparalleled connectivity, professionalism and platform that Panama possesses can be utilised by brands and firms from Tamil Nadu to promote products and expand markets, according to Alonso Correa Miguel, Ambassador of Panama to India.

Panama is the natural bridge between North and South America and the logistic link between the Pacific and the Atlantic oceans, he said while speaking to businesspersons in Chennai on Friday.

Maritime and pharmaceutical businesses from Chennai explored opportunities in Panama and the Latin American region at the event.

Single base in Latam

Panama connects world trade through the Canal, the Colón Free Zone, one of the largest ship registries and a dollar economy serving 20 Latin American markets.

"Tamil Nadu, with an economy about four times the size of Panama's, exported around $59 billion worth of goods in 2025-26 and accounted for a third or more of India's electronics and vehicle exports. Panama can give Tamil Nadu's manufacturers a single base for Latin America," he added.

Infosys Q2 net rises 6% to ₹7,823 crore, announces ₹26/share interim dividend

Mini Tejaswi
BENGALURU

Infosys reported a 6.2% year-on-year growth in net profit to ₹7,823 crore in the second quarter of FY27 while revenue rose 10.7% to ₹49,244 crore. In Q2, it won large deals worth $5.2 billion, with 62% of the wins being net new.

Cautious on overall market environment, the firm trimmed revenue growth projection for FY27 to 1%-2%, down from previous 1.5%-3% though it retained full-year operating margin guidance at 20%-22%.

The company indicated guidance was cut due to various factors, including a softer second quarter, subdued volumes, pricing pressure and higher productivity expectations from clients in addition to weakness in discretionary spending across retail and high-tech sectors, even as the IT services major reported strong AI and large deal wins in the September quarter. It also said the revised revenue outlook reflected the challenges of converting AI-led productivity gains into incremental revenue while managing competitive intensity in traditional services unit.



Keeping pace: Q2 also saw a rise in AI-related revenue at 10.5% of total revenue, up from 8.2% a year earlier. REUTERS

Jayesh Sanghrajka, CFO, in an earnings call said, "Q2 has been softer and volume continues to remain softer. We have also seen pricing pressure on the back of competitive intensity and higher ask on productivity."

Q2 also saw a rise in AI-related revenue at 10.5% of total revenue, up from 8.2% a year earlier. It delivered operating margins of 21% in Q2. The board announced an interim dividend of ₹26/share. Infosys reported a net addition of 4,000 staff in Q2, including 8,000 fresh graduates.

Jio IPO sees a record over 1 cr. applications

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Jio Platforms Ltd's initial public offering (IPO) crossed a milestone on the closing day when it became the first issue globally to secure over one crore applications crossing Waaree Energies' 97 lakh.

The ₹30,213 crore IPO closed on Friday with a total demand of more than ₹7 lakh crore. Investors bid for more than 20.5 times the issue, making it the highest-value bid in India.

Jio Platforms Ltd., the largest company by market share in India's telecom sector, opened for subscripton on Wednesday with investors fully subscribing in 100 minutes making it one of the fastest-subscribed IPOs in India.

Typically, foreign investors and institutional buyers wait until the last day before bidding to gauge investor sentiment.

However, Jio Platform's issue was bid over 10 times by qualified institutional buyers on day 2. As per latest data from NSE, QIB demand rose as high as almost 15 times. Retail investors' demand crossed 2.03 times with biddings worth 17.29 crore shares.

According to latest reports, bids were largely placed at the upper end of the price band of ₹1,119 with total demand exceeding $15 billion.

TAIPEI

China using militia ships to expand reach into western Pacific: Taiwan



REUTERS

China is combining militia vessels with coast guard ships to expand "battlefield preparation" around Taiwan and into the western Pacific, Taiwan said, warning the operations were also putting pressure on Japan and the Philippines. A Chinese militia boat was spotted off Taiwan's Pacific coast in mid-August. REUTERS

KYIV

Two soldiers died after arrested girl sent Russian poison: Ukraine



AP

Ukrainian police said they had detained a 17-year-old girl after she sent "free drugs" to soldiers on the instructions of a Russian handler in exchange for money and that two had died. Ukraine and Russia have throughout their war since 2022 accused each other of recruiting minors for sabotage acts including poisoning. AFP

GENEVA

UN condemns 'horrifying toll' of increasing drone attacks in Sudan



REUTERS

The UN said on Friday drone attacks in Sudan had killed over 300 people so far in October, accusing both the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces of launching such attacks, often on civilian targets. "The increasing use of drones is deeply disturbing and is exacting a horrifying toll," UN rights chief Volker Turk said. AFP

ATHENS

Greece passes legislation banning social media for children under 15



REUTERS

Greece's Parliament passed a law on Friday banning children under 15 from social media, joining a growing number of countries imposing curbs on young people's use of the apps. The Bill, set to take effect on January 1, will require age verification on social networks and impose penalties if companies fail to comply. AFP

Israel launches major West Bank operation after two soldiers killed

Netanyahu orders lockdown in occupied West Bank, says Army preparing for an operation on a scale unseen in decades; Ministers announce demolition of buildings, seek dismantling of Palestinian Authority; attack comes ahead of Tuesday vote

Agence France-Presse
HEBRON

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu announced a major military operation in the occupied West Bank on Friday after Palestinian gunmen killed two soldiers in an attack near Hebron, days ahead of Israeli elections in which security has been a central focus.

Mr. Netanyahu is locked in a tight race to keep his job in Tuesday's vote, having campaigned on promises to keep Israelis safe, and he and his right-wing allies visited the scene of the attack to pledge an even harder line on West Bank militancy.

The first steps would see Hebron residents displaced, homes searched and "terrorist infrastructure" destroyed, the Premier said, threatening operations on a scale unseen since Israel first occupied the Palestinian territory in 1967.



Mounting tensions: Israeli settlers gather as Israeli forces guard the site of the attack in Hebron on Friday. REUTERS

He said the military would apply a model previously used in refugee camps in the northern West Bank, scene of a large-scale operation launched in 2025 that the UN said forcibly displaced thousands.

Militant group Hamas, without claiming responsibility, praised the attack as a "heroic operation".

The gun battle broke out at the Farsh al-Hawa checkpoint between soldiers and two armed Palestinian men, with Israeli forces eventually shooting the attackers dead.

The Army later said that two of its soldiers "fell in combat in the Judea Junction" area, with three others wounded.

Mr. Netanyahu in a statement lauded the soldiers' response, crediting them with having "prevented what could have been a major attack" and ordering a lockdown in the West Bank.

Far-right Israeli Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich announced that building demolitions were under way. Earlier in the day, he had called for a large-scale military offensive in the West Bank "exactly like in Gaza".

Far-right National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir said the "Palestinian Authority must be dismantled".

No evidence suggests that the Palestinian Authority, which exercises limited self-rule in parts of the West Bank, was connected to Friday's attack.

Hamas hails attack

Hamas hailed Friday's shooting as a "natural and legitimate response to the ongoing crimes and brutal attacks against our people".

In a statement, the group denounced Israeli "military checkpoints fragmenting the cities and villages of the occupied West Bank".

France, U.K. stage first joint nuclear air strike simulation

Agence France-Presse
PARIS



Winged allies: The exercise involved RAF Typhoon fighter jets alongside French Rafale aircraft over the Mediterranean Sea. AP

French and British air forces have for the first time staged a joint exercise simulating a nuclear strike, the countries' Defence Ministries said in a statement on Friday.

The exercise, codenamed 'Rummy', took place on Tuesday and involved RAF Typhoon fighter jets alongside French Rafale aircraft over the Mediterranean Sea, it said.

The exercise did not involve any actual nuclear weapons and was aimed at enhancing coordination between western Europe's two nuclear powers, the statement added.

After taking off from a base in northeastern France, "the French Rafales, escorted by RAF Typhoons, conducted a simulated nuclear strike", it said.

French President Emmanuel Macron has offered to extend the protection of France's nuclear deterrent to other European allies, as the European Union's only nuclear power since Brexit.

French Defence Minister Catherine Vautrin noted that "possessing independent nuclear forces does not preclude coordination".

The joint exercise showed "our nuclear forces demonstrate that they can contribute even more significantly to the overall security" of NATO, she said.

U.K. Defence Minister Wes Streeting said the exercise marked a "new chapter" in the relationship between Britain and France on nuclear defence.

Writing on X, he said: "It's a landmark step in U.K.-France defence cooperation, and a clear signal that we stand shoulder to shoulder with our allies on European security and credible deterrence."

French authorities to deploy 70,000 police ahead of new protests

Reuters
PARIS

France will deploy 70,000 police for protests on Saturday, Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said on Friday, accusing ultra-left groups of encouraging violence and looting after unrest shocked the country last weekend.

"We will be uncompromising with rioters, looters and all those who commit acts of violence," Mr. Nunez told reporters on Friday.

Mr. Nunez said authorities had identified numerous online calls from hard-left groups encouraging attacks and urging activists to target public buildings.

Police have authorised only a union demonstration in Paris on Saturday, rejecting requests for rallies lodged by France's main student union, UNEF, and the Yellow Vest movement, an anti-establishment force that first emerged in 2018.

Fears of renewed turmoil prompted several of Paris' best-known cultural institutions, including the Louvre, to close on Saturday. Business groups also urged shops to stay shut after some 3,000 stores and businesses were ransacked last weekend.

Unlikely besties



Home away from home: Petar Pero Tubic sits with pet female bears Masa, right, and Ljiubica, left, on Mount Ozren, near the town of Doboj, Bosnia. The pair's friendship began in 2019 when Mr. Tubic found Masa abandoned as a cub in a forest and took her home. They have been inseparable ever since. He has since adopted Ljubica who also lives on the property. AP

First Russian diesel tanker from Putin deal heading for U.S.

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

A tanker filled with Russian diesel is headed for New York, maritime trackers and the Kremlin confirmed on Friday, after the U.S. eased sanctions in a deal that shocked Ukraine and its European allies.

U.S. President Donald Trump struck the deal with President Vladimir Putin this month as Russia's war against Ukraine dragged on and as his relations with Ukrainian leader Volodymyr Zelenskyy plummeted.

The agreement is widely seen as an attempt by Mr. Trump to lower U.S. fuel prices ahead of mid-term elections next month.

The tanker *Agioi Fanendes* was located off Helsinki on Friday and indicated "New York" as its destination on its AIS transponder signal, according to maritime tracking firm Kpler. The ship left Russia's Baltic port of Primorsk overnight, after loading nearly 300,000 barrels of diesel, Kpler said. It was due to reach New York around November 7.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov confirmed that the "first tanker set sail for its intended recipients, its buyers".

Search on for survivors after deadly quake in China's Tibet region kills 16

Associated Press
BEIJING

Rescuers combed through a remote area in the Chinese region of Tibet on Friday after a magnitude 7 earthquake that killed at least 16 people, injuring 76 and collapsing hundreds of homes, according to Chinese state media.

The disaster struck Nagqu, a city north of Tibet's capital Lhasa that's some 4,800 metres above sea level, on Thursday. At least 339 homes collapsed, and officials were concerned about building collapses from aftershocks, as well as casualties from rockslides.



In the aftermath: A drone photo shows damaged houses after a quake struck Nagqu in China's Tibet autonomous region. AP

More than 5,000 people from three local counties were deployed for rescue efforts. As of Friday afternoon, rescuers had done three rounds of searches, said Dunzhu, the acting Mayor of Nagqu city.

The U.S. Geological Survey said the quake occurred at 10:33 p.m. local time on Thursday, with its epicentre 191 kilometres east-northeast of Nagqu.

The U.S. agency recorded at least seven aftershocks with magnitude between 4.3 and 5.2.

'All-out efforts'

Chinese President Xi Jinping called for all-out efforts in rescue operations and medical relief work on Friday morning.

Mr. Xi said the tremor caused "significant casualties" and took place at a "high-altitude location" in cold weather.

"(We) must go all-out to carry out search and rescue operations and do our utmost to treat the injured, so as to minimise casualties," Xinhua quoted Mr. Xi as saying.

(With inputs from AFP)

U.S. envoy says Washington could strike Iran this weekend

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Ambassador contradicts Israeli premier, says U.S. is not interested in regime change

The United States could strike Iran as soon as this weekend, a U.S. envoy said on Friday, after mounting threats by both Washington and Israel.

"Could there be a strike this weekend? Absolutely," Tom Barrack, the U.S. Ambassador to Turkey, told Israeli army radio in response to a question.

President Donald Trump "is very clear. He's open and available and accessible to a deal and we've been at the table for months and months and months," Mr. Barrack said in the interview.

Mr. Trump, a business partner and friend of Mr. Barrack, downplayed the remarks when asked to confirm an attack could come this weekend.

"That was my Ambassador? He's a pretty powerful man, I guess. If that's the case, I don't know anything about it," Mr. Trump told reporters in Florida.

Mr. Trump has signaled an openness to resuming strikes after a long deadlock in diplomacy, although he earlier said it would not happen before U.S. congressional elections on November 3.

Mr. Barrack, in remarks that contradict Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, said the U.S. was not looking to topple the Islamic republic.

"If you keep threatening the world, our allies, the Gulf, there will be a consequence. The consequence won't be regime change," Mr. Barrack said.

"The U.S. is not interested in regime change," he added. "The problem with regime change always is, what's the day-two scenario?"

Melania forges ceasefire for Ukrainian city

Reuters
WASHINGTON

U.S. first lady Melania Trump has secured a ceasefire between Russia and Ukraine in the Russian-controlled city of Oleshky, which will begin on October 29, the White House said on Friday.

"Both nations agreed to temporarily stop all military action in Oleshky to allow for humanitarian aid to enter," a White House statement said.

"Oleshky is a front-line war city. Its remaining population is primarily elderly residents who need medical attention and food," Ms. Melania said.



Poll duty: A worker carries boxes with electronic voting machines at a polling station in Brazil on Friday. REUTERS

Brazil's Indigenous people in Amazon struggle to vote

Associated Press
SAO PAULO

Brazilian prosecutors and advocates for Indigenous people are suing to force electoral authorities to help voters in remote Amazon communities exercise their constitutionally guaranteed right to cast ballots in Sunday's presidential run-off.

Leftist President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva and his far-right challenger, Senator Flávio Bolsonaro, a son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, have markedly different approaches to protecting the Amazon, and the race is tight according to recent polls. The Articulation of Indigenous Peoples of Brazil, known as Apib, announced Thursday that it filed an urgent request for the Justice Inspector General's Office to make sure electoral officials act quickly to help Indigenous people reach voting centres.

And federal prosecutors filed a lawsuit Wednesday in federal court in Para seeking a nationwide order to ensure Indigenous peoples can vote, by providing free transportation by river, land or air, and by funding food, interpreters, cultural facilitators and signs in Indigenous languages at polling places.

The prosecutors' suit cites accounts from communities across Brazil, including allegations that municipal governments denied transportation for political reasons and ranchers prevented Indigenous workers from leaving farms to vote.

The Brazilian government's Indigenous affairs agency, Funai, told *AP* it has consulted communities about transportation needs for the run-off but said state electoral authorities are responsible for arranging it.

Trump govt. offers mixed messages on limits to Ukraine's access to Starshield

Kyiv has not received an explanation of who ordered the restrictions placed on Musk's satellite Internet service last week; even as Trump maintains he didn't make the call, Vance has hinted at White House coordination with Musk, while Rubio and Hegseth denied any administration involvement

Associated Press

Recent efforts to throttle Ukraine's access to satellite systems have created a blame game of sorts among Trump administration officials and their allies, who have offered mixed messages about what led to the sudden restrictions on Kyiv's ability to intercept Russian strikes.

The limitations placed on Starshield – SpaceX's military-grade version of the Starlink satellite Internet service and the backbone of Ukraine's drone operations and communication – last week alarmed the country's military and government officials, with commanders reporting lost drones and disrupted missions. After days of handwringing, President Donald Trump asserted Thursday that the service is running again at full speed.

However, restrictions were still in place on Friday, according to Serhii "Flash" Beskrestnov, an adviser to President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

"We have not seen any indication that Starlink's restrictions have been lifted," he said in a post on social media. A senior European official familiar with the situation on the ground in Ukraine said Thursday that the speed cap was still set at about 100 mph (160 kph). Ukraine has not received a clear official explanation of who ordered the restrictions or why, according to the official.

The episode and subsequent lack of accountability have sent shock waves through Russia hawks and Ukraine's allies on Capitol Hill. Democratic Senator Richard Blumenthal announced a new inquiry into how the technologies were slowed down for Ukraine's defence systems.

Questions have percolated since last week about who ordered the interruptions to the Elon Musk-made satellite Internet system that Ukraine has relied on for years to counter Moscow's attacks.

Mr. Trump, as recently as Thursday, has maintained that he didn't make the call. Vice President J.D. Vance has hinted at White House coordination with Mr. Musk, while Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth have denied any administration involvement. Mr. Musk – one of the Republican Party's biggest donors and a Trump ally – indicated that because Ukraine was using the military-grade version of his technology, questions about the service should be directed to the Pentagon.

Here are the players in their own words:



Ukrainian soldiers set up Starlink satellite Internet system near the front line town of Pokrovsk in Donetsk region in April 2025. REUTERS

Over the last week, Mr. Trump has repeatedly told reporters that he didn't order restrictions on a satellite communications system used by Ukraine's military, causing its drones to lose speed. The President also earlier doubted the disruption came from Mr. Musk. "Well, I don't know if it was anybody, but it wasn't me, and I don't think it was Elon," he said Friday.

'A private corporation'

On Thursday, Mr. Trump appeared to confirm that the service had been down and claimed that it was once again working at optimal speeds. The Wall Street Journal reported that Mr. Musk had agreed to lift restrictions, and Mr. Trump demurred when asked if he had requested to lift the cap.

"You know, whether I called or whether somebody else called, doesn't make any difference," Mr. Trump told reporters. "I guess the bottom line, he put it back."

In Cincinnati on Thursday, Mr. Vance was asked about Mr. Musk's involvement in the slowdown of Starlink and Starshield in Ukraine and whether it warranted an investigation. "I think that fundamentally, Elon Musk runs a private corporation," Mr. Vance told reporters.

"And I think it's completely understandable that he doesn't want to get in the middle of what is a war between two state actors without the United States government effectively directing him on what to do."

Mr. Vance continued: "So I don't think this is about Elon. I think it's fundamentally what is America's policy in Ukraine and Russia going to be." Mr. Rubio has insisted that the Trump administration and the U.S. government more broadly had nothing to do with interruptions to Ukraine's access to crucial satellite data.

Speaking to reporters in India on Wednesday, he said for the third time in four days that any throttling of network access to Ukraine was not directed or ordered by Mr. Trump or anyone else in his administration. He suggested, though, that the owner of the system – Mr. Musk – may have been involved.

"The President has nothing to do with the decisions that are made by Starlink and Starshield and by Mr. Musk. That's a private company. The President doesn't run that company and can't direct that company to do anything."

Mr. Hegseth has echoed Mr. Rubio's comments, denying on Tuesday any American role in slowing down the satellite Internet service while also pushing the responsibility to Mr. Musk's company.

"We haven't pulled anything back," Mr. Hegseth told reporters, before adding that "there are terms of service that ultimately need to be complied to."

He offered no elaboration on what terms of service Ukraine needed to comply with but said that "Starlink has the option to make those decisions."

Mr. Musk, the world's richest man and leader of the company behind Starlink and Starshield, last week put the onus on the Trump administration.

"Starshield systems are owned and controlled by the U.S. government. Any limits on speed or usage are decided by the U.S. military and ultimately POTUS," he wrote October 14 on X.

"Starlink is a commercial service owned and controlled by SpaceX. Usage of Starlink is limited to civilian or defensive activities and cannot be used for offensive military action, as doing so would be inappropriate for a commercial company," he added.

Shortly after the systems failed to work, Mr. Zelenskyy said that there were no similar restrictions in European Union countries and that they apply only to Ukraine.

"In other words, this is a planned operation," he said.

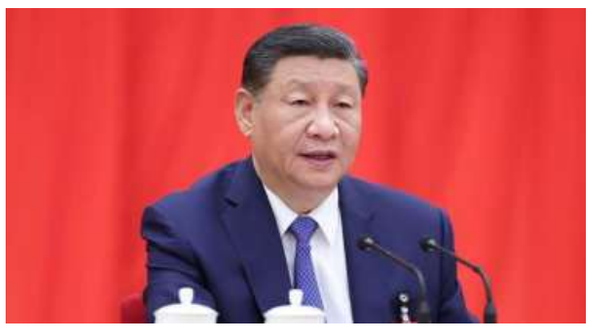
Mr. Zelenskyy spoke to a bipartisan group of U.S. lawmakers Monday, saying in a video of the briefing posted to social media that "we still face speed restrictions on Starlink and Starshield services in different parts of the front, and we still have no explanation for this. Just different strange stories."

Tougher discipline, Xi's power key at Communist Party's fifth plenum

Reuters
BEIJING

China's ruling Communist Party will gather some 300 of its highest-ranking members next week to discuss tightening discipline among its ranks, a conclave analysts say could be the last major party gathering before its 2027 leadership reshuffle.

Although experts widely expect President Xi Jinping to hold onto the party top job for a fourth term at next year's 21st Party Congress, the upcoming plenary session – known as a plenum – offers him an opportunity to shore up authority, enforce ideological uniformity and cement his imprint on the party that rules the world's second-largest economy.



Experts widely expect President Xi Jinping to hold onto the party top job for a fourth term at next year's 21st Party Congress. AP

The officials will deliberate "issues concerning the sustained advancement of full and rigorous party self-governance", the party has said, as Mr. Xi steps up an internal discipline campaign he introduced in 2014, two years after ascending to power.

The Communist Party's current Central Committee, the largest of its top decision-making bodies, will convene in the closed-door meeting in Beijing from Monday to Thursday – the fifth since the current cohort was formed in 2022 and therefore known as the fifth plenum.

Many of Mr. Xi's closest associates are likely to retire in the 2027 reshuffle and "disciplinary campaigns are a way to ensure a new generation with fewer personal ties share his political standards," said Ruby Osman, a senior policy adviser on China at London's Tony Blair Institute.

Despite a thinning leadership body, analysts do not expect major personnel moves or any indication of a potential succession plan at the four-day conclave.

"This plenum is probably less about deciding individual promotions, more about signalling the system-wide changes Xi wants ahead of a competitive 2027 Party Congress," Ms. Osman said.

Reduced to rubble



First responders clear debris after a building under construction collapsed in the Eastleigh neighbourhood of Nairobi, Kenya, on Friday. AFP

From mountain fighters to 'regional power', a look at the rise of Yemen's Houthis

Agence France-Presse
DUBAI

The Houthis emerged from obscurity in Yemen's hard-scrabble north to control swathes of the country and pose a perennial threat to neighbouring Saudi Arabia, the world's top oil exporter.

From their origins in the 1990s, the Iran-backed former mountain fighters now command the status of regional players capable of inflicting pain on global shipping and oil prices.

Like the other armed members of Iran's "Axis of Resistance", the Houthis are hostile to the West, as befits their slogan: "Death to America, death to Israel." But unlike Lebanon's Hezbollah, the Houthis, who took the capital Sanaa in 2014 and have weathered a long-running war with a Saudi-led coalition, were not created by Iran.

'Not taking orders'

"At the beginning, there were no structured ties between Iran and the movement," explains Mohammed Azzan, a scholar of Islamic thought who witnessed the Houthis' emergence in Saada, northern Yemen, in the 1990s. "Relations developed gradually as both sides discovered common interests."

Their bond has strengthened since the Gaza war.

The Houthis have been "drawing closer to Iran in pursuit of their own ambitions, without necessarily being under its orders", says Maysaa Shuja al-Deen, a researcher at the Sanaa Center for Strategic Studies think-tank.

Their lightning offensive in September, when they captured the parts of the Red Sea coast not already under their control, illustrates the alignment of interests.

Control of the strategic Bab el-Mandeb strait, the Red Sea's southern gateway, while Tehran is choking the Strait of Hormuz on the other side of the Arabian Peninsula, "increases Iran's bargaining power," while giving the Houthis "enormous leverage" over Riyadh, says Thomas Juneau of the University of Ottawa.

When it was launched in 2001, the movement styled itself as representing Saada, the cradle of Zaydism – a branch of Shia Islam, but different to that favoured in Iran. The northern city, the centre of Yemeni power for centuries, had become marginalised by the central government in Sanaa. The movement's founder, Hussein Badreddin al-Houthi, the son of a prominent religious figure, was already denouncing Israel and the U.S., using rhetoric inspired by Iran's Islamic revolution.



Locked and loaded: A supporter carries a rifle during a pro-Houthi rally in Sanaa, Yemen, on October 9. AP

After he was killed by Yemeni authorities in 2004, the group, later named Ansar Allah (Supporters of God), became more radical under his brother, Abdulmalik al-Houthi. Holed up in the northern mountains, his followers waged six wars against President Ali Abdullah Saleh before joining the uprising that drove him from power in 2012.

In 2014, the Houthis nonetheless allied with Saleh and seized the reins of power in Sanaa, marking the start of their conquest of large parts of Yemen. Saleh was killed three years later, after turning against the Houthis.

Saudi Arabia intervened at the head of a military coalition supporting the exiled government in early 2015, increasing Iran's interest in the Houthis. Although Iran denies giving support, Yemen's government announced the first seizure of arms destined for the Houthis in 2013.

Ms. Deen said Iranian assistance grew from 2016, including the transfer of military expertise as well as communication and negotiation techniques, first through Hezbollah and then directly from Iran.

The Al-Masirah TV channel was launched in Hezbollah's stronghold of southern Beirut before moving to Sanaa, broadcasting Houthi propaganda and Abdulmalik al-Houthi's speeches.

Rarely appearing in public, he cultivates the image of a spiritual guide and defender of the Muslim world against the West and the Gulf countries, which he accuses of serving American interests.

'Disproportionate pain'

Thanks to Iran, the Houthis have acquired drones and long-range missiles, allowing them to establish an "asymmetric balance of power" with Saudi Arabia, says Mr. Juneau.

For years, they absorbed Saudi airstrikes by "exploiting Yemen's geography" while "inflicting disproportionate pain" on their neighbour by targeting its infrastructure.

After a truce in 2022 calmed fighting, the movement built up its military production capacity and diversified its arms supply chain, sourcing from China and Russia.

A report published by The Century Foundation think-tank in February said 35% of arms and materials intercepted en route to the Houthis between 2021 and 2025 originated in China.

Iran was the next biggest supplier with 21%.

"Without Iranian assistance, the Houthis would not be a regional power today," says Mr. Juneau.

The Houthis have also benefited from recruiting elements of the former national Army, forging alliances with tribes and, most importantly, the "weakness" of the government, which is plagued with internal divisions.

"This has been as essential as Iranian assistance to the story of the Houthis' rise," Mr. Juneau says.

OUT AND IN

Kishan unavailable for second game, Kushagra added as cover



X@BCCI

India batter Ishan Kishan will be unavailable for the second T20 International against New Zealand in Christchurch owing to a right adductor strain that he suffered in the series-opener. "Ishan Kishan is ruled out due to a low grade right adductor strain," the BCCI said. Kumar Kushagra has been added to the squad as cover.

KEEPING IT SIMPLE

There was not really anything to overcomplicate, says Dhir



AP

Actually, we discussed that if we hit two good shots, just proper cricketing shots, two boundaries, then the game would end right there. There was not really anything to overcomplicate — India all-rounder Naman Dhir, who made an unbeaten 15-ball 42, on the conversation with skipper Shreyas Iyer in the middle.

BELOVED'S DISTINCTION

Biza becomes second youngest to make a half-century against India



X@ZIMBABWECRICKET

Zimbabwe's Beloved Biza, at 17y 9m 19d, became the second youngest after England's Sarah Taylor (17y 3m 5d) to make a 50-plus score against India in women's ODIs. Her 92-ball 62 kept the Indian bowlers at bay and took the visitors to 197. "I was looking to play straight and bat as many overs as I could," said Biza.

AT THE HELM

Awana to head the BCCI junior selection committee



BCCI

Former India pacer Parvinder Awana, who played two T20Is, was on Friday appointed chairman of the newly formed BCCI junior selection committee. The other members of the panel are Krishna Das, Rakesh Patel and N. Arjun Yadav. "The fifth member will be appointed shortly," said the BCCI.

Bowlers under the lens as another run-fest beckons

Sooryavanshi likely to get an opportunity in India's playing XI in place of the injured Kishan; New Zealand skipper Santner says the biggest challenge will be to contain the visiting team's top-order which ran riot in the opener

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH



Blazing away: Samson and Abhishek's blistering start provided the ideal launchpad for the big chase. AFP

The rescue act by the batters was impressive but India's bowling attack needs to find its rhythm and figure out a way to contain a rather destructive New Zealand in the second T20 International here on Saturday.

As has been the case of late, the batters saved the day for India after the bowlers endured another ordinary outing. The record chase of 226 gave the visiting team a crucial 1-0 lead but it also highlighted frailties that can cost the side heavily in the remainder of the five-match series.

A concern

The fifth and sixth bowling options have been a concern for India with the all-rounders not yet doing justice to those roles in the absence of an injury-prone Hardik Pandya.

Finn Allen and his fellow opener Tim Seifert were able to pick Bhuvneshwar and Arshdeep Singh for boundaries at will in the PowerPlay, putting the seasoned duo under immense pressure.

Like on Thursday night, the conditions are expected to be ideal for batting, leaving the bowlers with very little room for error. Axar Patel, too, would be under pressure, having given away the most runs in the first T20.

On the batting front, the Indian and New Zealand supporters will, in all likelihood, get to see Vaibhav Sooryavanshi bat. The space in the playing XI has been created due to Ishan Kishan's injury. In Mitchell Santner's own words, his team's biggest challenge on Saturday night would be to contain the in-form Indian top-order.

In top gear

Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma wreaked havoc in the PowerPlay, putting the New Zealand bowlers to the sword.

Considering the depth of the Indian batting, New Zealand will surely need to bowl better to make a match of it.

The teams (from):
New Zealand: Mitchell Santner (Capt.), Finn Allen, Michael Bracewell, Mark Chapman, Devon Conway, Jacob Duffy, Lockie Ferguson, Zak Foulkes, Matt Henry, Bevon Jacobs, Kyle Jamieson, Adam Milne, Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips, Tim Seifert, and Nathan Smith.

India: Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Tilak Varma (Vice-capt.), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Axar Patel, Shivam Dube, Nitish Kumar, Naman Dhir, Kumar Kushagra, Prince Yadav, Mayank Yadav, Arshdeep Singh, Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Varun Chakaravarthy, and Kuldeep Yadav.

Match starts at 12.30 p.m. IST.

Kotak praises 'fearless attitude' of the openers

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH



Marauding batters: Abhishek, Sooryavanshi and Samson can take the game away from the opposition in a jiffy. ANI

India batting coach Sitanshu Kotak, on Friday, lavished praise on openers Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma, saying that the big-hitters have immense control over their minds apart from "power, talent and intent".

Kotak added that the think-tank should be "appreciated" for sticking with Samson and Abhishek despite the social media-fuelled clamour for the inclusion of 15-year-old sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

"There is a lot of speculation on social media about the three openers. So, sometimes, social media should also appreciate that the management calls are for the good of the team. People want to play their own XI, but it does not work like that," Kotak said on the eve of the second T20I against New Zealand here.

"Sanju is outstanding, he is a power-packed player. If you ever put yourself in the place of a batter and think that you have to hit three or four sixes in the first two overs, you will be afraid of getting out. If you get out early in two or three games, you would think that you would get dropped. So, overcoming all that and the intent they (openers) are showing... that excites me.

"It is amazing that on top of power, talent and intent, they are controlling their minds. To get them into that fearless attitude... it is unbelievable," added Kotak.

The coach felt that the hype surrounding a young player like Sooryavanshi was not good for him. "Everyone is saying that he should play, but he is not getting the space. He is too young. It is sad and it is sad for the other players who are performing. People related to cricket, they should think about it," Kotak said, adding that the teenager was constantly learning and had never complained about being left out.

Pratika's unbeaten century makes it a walk in the park

ZIMBABWE IN INDIA

Lavanya L.
VADODARA



Terrific trio: Pratika and Shafali piled on Zimbabwe's misery with an unbroken 106-run stand after Shree Charani kept the away team in check. BCCI

On October 23, 2025, Pratika Rawal and Smriti Mandhana registered stunning centuries against New Zealand to bring a struggling ODI World Cup campaign back on track in Navi Mumbai.

Exactly a year later, Pratika (100 n.o., 96b, 15x4), with help from a marauding Shafali Verma (64 n.o., 33b, 5x4, 4x6), raised her bat once more to earn India a crushing nine-wicket win over Zimbabwe in the first ODI at the BCA Stadium here on Friday.

A struggle

Zimbabwe avoided a collective slow roast under the scorching sun and India's big-hitting prowess by opting to bat first, but struggled to get going on the red-soil pitch.

The home team's tight lines and smart use of early swing condemned the visitor to a nervy crawl.

The Lady Chevrons managed three partnerships of over 40 runs. Chipo Mugeri-Tiripano and Modester Mupachikwa resisted the host's charge, after which 17-year-old Beloved Biza took over, making best use of India's wavering concentration to notch up her fourth ODI fifty.

Also useful for the away side were a few blips in the field and the occasional width given, especially by Deepti Sharma and debutant Jintimani Kalita.

N. Shree Charani (four for 23), however, punctuated any audacity shown with a miserly effort and four wickets to record her best figures in the format.

An enterprising cameo by Michelle Mavunga kept alive Zimbabwe's dream of a total in excess of 200, only for it to guttingly fall short of that mark by three runs.

Chasing a meagre 198, Smriti and Pratika's 94-run opening stand reduced Zimbabwe to a herd of deer in the headlights. Olinder Chare dismissed Smriti in the 16th over, but Shafali, batting at No. 3 for only the second time in the format, didn't disappoint.

Her 106-run unbroken partnership with Pratika sealed the contest with 137 balls to spare, getting India off to a winning start in the ICC Championship.

The scores: Zimbabwe 197 in 49.5 overs (Beloved Biza 62, N. Shree Charani 4/23, Kranti Gaud 3/42) lost to India 200/1 in 27.1 overs (Pratika Rawal 100 n.o., Shafali Verma 64 n.o.). **Toss:** Zimbabwe; **PoM:** Pratika.

Good to be back in the room and score runs, says Pratika

Lavanya L.
VADODARA

Who will open with Smriti Mandhana? This was the big question on the lips of those watching along as India set out to chase 198 in the first ODI against Zimbabwe here on Friday.

Smriti, recently appointed full-time skipper, opted to open with Pratika Rawal, sending Shafali Verma to No. 3, a spot usually occupied by Jemimah Rodrigues, who is missing due to injury.

The results will have no one complaining, though, with Pratika scoring a solid century and Shafali blitzing away to a half-century, securing a simple win for India in the process.

"Before going in to bat, I saw highlights on the TV of the game against New Zealand (from the 2025 World Cup), and I thought that was the game where I scored my last hundred," Pratika said after the game.

"Good to be back in the room, always good to score runs and contribute to a team's victory by batting as long as I can. It was one of those days when the ball went where I wanted it to. Luckily, it turned out really good," she added.

Happy to learn

Shafali, barely made for the slow-steady mode, was aware of the limitations of the no.3 role.

"Of course, I didn't get that 10 over PowerPlay with just two fielders outside. I just tried to take the singles and I will learn these things. ODIs are testing my patience, but I am really happy to learn," she quipped.

The win was set up by N. Shree Charani's career-best figures of four for 23, which included three maiden overs on a pitch that didn't have much turn for the tweakers. "I bowled to my strengths. I just focused on my lengths. In our bowling meetings before every game, we work on sticking to the channel and on attacking the stumps. We did that today," the 22-year-old said.

El Clasico: Flick, Mourinho and the morbo of all morbos

The iconic fixture that pits Barcelona versus Real Madrid continues to stop the world. Why does it evoke such interest? Why is there such 'needle' between the sides? And how will the managers of the two Spanish giants set their sides up for the latest edition of this bitter rivalry?

Srinivasan Ramani

When Real Madrid turns out against Barcelona on Sunday, expect a global audience of more than 600 million, much higher than even the largely India-based viewership of close to 400 million for the IPL final.

Why does El Clasico command such a vast, loyal following? One reason is football excellence: the two clubs have dominated Spain and Europe over the last two decades. Another is that they hosted two of the world's most famous athletes – Lionel Messi (Barcelona) and Cristiano Ronaldo (Madrid). The fan-bases built during that period have outlasted the two superstars.

What gives the fixture its heft is the rivalry's intensity – an antagonism that springs from historical, political and cultural divisions

Proxy battles

What gives the fixture its heft, though, is the rivalry's intensity. Phil Ball in 'Morbo: the Story of Spanish Football' describes "morbo" as a uniquely Spanish brand of antagonistic "needle" that turns football matches into proxy battles over historical, political and cultural divides.

El Clasico is the morbo of all morbos. Real, the capital city's main club, symbolises central Spain's grandeur, but reminds detractors of patronage from dictator Franco's regime. Barcelona, 'mes que un club' (more than a club), is a voice for Catalan identity which the dictatorship suppressed. But both are owned by members and run by business elites – the contrast is sharper in perception than in fact.

On the pitch, though, the difference is real. It dates back to Dutch great Johan Cruyff, who played for Barcelona (1973-78) and returned as coach in 1988 with totaalvoetbal, or total football. His 'Dream Team' won Barcelona's first European Cup in 1992 with a young Pep Guardiola at its heart.

When Guardiola became the coach in 2008, he took Cruyff's ideas to their furthest point with a team built largely on homegrown talent such as Xavi, Andres Iniesta, Sergio Busquets and Messi. It won 14 trophies in four seasons, humiliating Madrid 6-2 at the Bernabeu in 2009 and 5-0 at Camp Nou in 2010.

Madrid's answer was to hire Guardiola's antithesis, Jose Mourinho. His Madrid was fast, direct and physical, content to cede the ball and strike on the break. The results were mixed. Madrid won the 2011 Copa del Rey and the 2011-12 league with a record 100 points, and an exhausted Guardiola left soon after. But Barcelona won the 2011 Champions League, and Mourinho departed in 2013 with a split dressing room.

In the decade after the coaching stalwarts left, Madrid won the Champions League six times, while Barcelona won more league titles before a financial crisis forced it to let Messi go in 2021. The revival came after Hansi Flick's appointment in 2024, built out of necessity on La Masia graduates such as teenagers Lamine Yamal and Pau Cubarsi. Barcelona has since won two successive league titles, while Madrid has gone two seasons without a major trophy. So president Florentino Perez turned to the coach he had once hired to stop Guardiola, Mourinho.

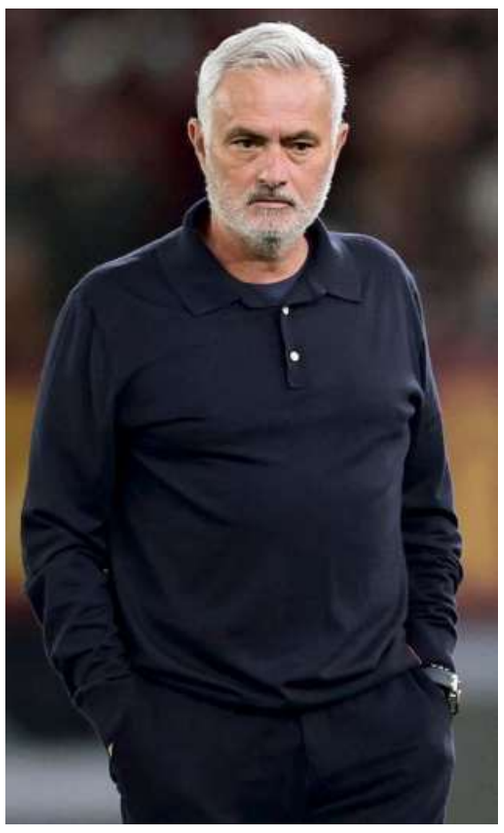


LAMINE YAMAL & KYLIAN MBAPPE

GETTY IMAGES



HANSI FLICK



JOSE MOURINHO

This season, Barcelona has won all nine of its league games, scoring 39 goals and conceding just nine. Having lost three strikers in the off-season, it is led by winger Raphinha, who now plays as a No. 9 and has scored 12 goals in seven games. With Yamal and Anthony Gordon alongside, the forwards harass defenders with relentless pressing. Barcelona averages 21 shots a game, and its expected goals (xG) stands at 33.6, a high 0.18 per shot.

The Yamal effect

Raphinha may be the tip of the spear, but this well-oiled Barca is lifted by Yamal who comes closest to what Messi was in the club's heyday: a dribbler who can cut through defences at will from the right wing, and a terrific passer with a repertoire of tricks. With eight goals and six assists in nine games, he has been decisive at just 19.

Behind the forwards, former Ballon d'Or winner Rodri, who chose Barca over Real, has provided the steadiness that Barca lacked after Busquets left in 2023, freeing the precocious Pedri to orchestrate play.

Under Flick, the system is built to take risks. Barcelona holds 69.4% of the ball, according to data from MarkStats, and its 'field tilt', the share of touches in the final third, is 72.7%, by far the highest in LaLiga. A high defensive line works as an offside trap: Barcelona catches opponents offside 3.1 times a game and allows only 6.8 shots.

But when opponents do get through, usually in transition, their chances are good ones, worth 0.18 xG each. The risk is mitigated by goalkeeper Joan Garcia, who sweeps behind his defence. Flick's style is far more vertical than Guardiola's patient possession, moving the ball quickly to wingers who take on their full-backs.

Mourinho's Madrid, in contrast, has struggled to recreate the hallowed Kroos-Modric midfield and a gulf remains between the midfield and a formidable forward line. Madrid's field tilt is just 51.5%, seventh in the league. It has scored 23 league goals, 16 fewer than Barcelona.

Kylian Mbappe remains lethal, but Vinicius Jr. has slumped badly, and the two often crowd each other on the left. Both are reluctant pressers which is partly why Madrid paid up to €140 million for 19-year-old winger Yan Diomande, who works hard without the ball.

Mourinho was brought back, by most accounts, because the club's hierarchy had tired of a dissonant dressing room that had too much power. But his methods may be outdated. In 2021, tactics writer Michael Cox argued that Mourinho's approach was out of step with modern football, which is 'about universality': pressing from the front, attacking from the back. His football has evolved since but his philosophy remains reactive.

Spain's football has largely been a duopoly because Madrid and Barcelona keep adapting to each other, never letting the other dominate for long

Playbook with potential

But that one win, a 2-1 victory at the Bernabeu a year ago under Xabi Alonso, was instructive. Alonso played Federico Valverde at right-back and Arda Guler in a three-man midfield. Mourinho used a similar playbook against Sevilla. A midfield that holds the ball, wide players who track back, and Mbappe attacking the space behind Barcelona's high line is a blueprint that gives Madrid a better chance of competing. Vinicius' absence through suspension seems a blessing in disguise.

Spain's football has largely been a duopoly because Madrid and Barcelona keep adapting to each other, never letting the other dominate for long. Under Flick, Barcelona has updated Cruyffian principles with modern-day pressing. Star-studded Madrid has bet on Mourinho, who once managed, at least for a while, to compete against Guardiola.

Yet as Guardiola said in 2011, Mourinho might be the "boss" in the press room, but Barcelona would fight it out on the pitch. On Sunday, we will know if the pitch is still the answer to the Mourinho question.

STACKING UP

ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	10,950	17
2	Alexander Zverev	29	10,070	20
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	5,610	17
4	Ben Shelton	24	4,720	22
5	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,660	23
6	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,640	25
7	F. Auger-Aliassime	26	3,590	22
8	Alex de Minaur	27	3,430	24
9	Frances Tiafoe	28	3,380	22
10	Arthur Fils	22	3,325	19
11	Rafael Jodar	20	3,234	21
12	Novak Djokovic	39	3,090	16
13	A. Davidovich Fokina	27	2,880	24
14	Taylor Fritz	28	2,880	22
15	Tommy Paul	29	2,575	22

Top Indians ▶



Sumit Nagal
Rank 281 ▼ 28 spots



Manas Dhamne
Rank 393 ▲ 9 spots

WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Elena Rybakina	27	9,196	20
2	Aryna Sabalenka	28	7,550	20
3	Mirra Andreeva	19	6,306	20
4	Jessica Pegula	32	6,235	19
5	Coco Gauff	22	5,974	19
6	Elina Svitolina	32	5,229	19
7	Karolina Muchova	30	4,833	19
8	Linda Noskova	21	4,678	19
9	Iga Swiatek	25	4,389	19
10	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,920	18
11	Maja Chwalinska	25	3,031	22
12	Iva Jovic	18	2,931	22
13	Diana Shnaider	22	2,663	22
14	Belinda Bencic	29	2,662	18
15	Elise Mertens	30	2,540	21

Top Indians ▶



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 365 ▲ 1 spot



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 378 ▼ 19 spots

English Premier League Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Man. City	7	7	0	0	19	7	12	21
2	Arsenal	7	6	0	1	11	5	6	18
3	Brighton	7	5	1	1	23	5	18	16
4	Chelsea	7	4	1	2	17	13	4	13
5	Liverpool	7	3	3	1	9	8	1	12
6	Brentford	7	2	4	1	13	8	5	10
7	Leeds United	7	2	4	1	9	6	3	10
8	Everton	7	2	4	1	8	7	1	10
9	Hull City	7	2	3	2	8	7	1	9
10	Ipswich Town	7	3	0	4	11	15	-4	9
11	Newcastle	7	2	2	3	10	14	-4	8
12	Aston Villa	7	2	2	3	7	11	-4	8
13	Man. United	7	1	4	2	10	10	0	7
14	Crystal Palace	7	2	1	4	9	17	-8	7
15	Bournemouth	7	1	3	3	9	13	-4	6
16	Tottenham	7	1	3	3	6	10	-4	6
17	Coventry City	7	2	0	5	6	14	-8	6
18	Fulham	7	1	2	4	7	10	-3	5
19	N. Forest	7	1	2	4	5	9	-4	5
20	Sunderland	7	1	1	5	6	14	-8	4

Italian Serie A Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Inter Milan	7	6	1	0	21	9	12	19
2	Lazio	7	6	1	0	14	4	10	19
3	Roma	7	5	2	0	16	3	13	17
4	AC Milan	7	4	3	0	14	7	7	15
5	Como	7	4	2	1	12	7	5	14
6	Frosinone	7	4	1	2	13	9	4	13
7	Cagliari	7	4	1	2	6	7	-1	13
8	Juventus	7	3	2	2	9	8	1	11
9	Napoli	7	3	1	3	10	7	3	10
10	Torino	7	3	1	3	10	9	1	10
11	Atalanta	7	3	0	4	10	11	-1	9
12	Lecce	7	3	0	4	9	12	-3	9
13	Sassuolo	7	2	2	3	12	14	-2	8
14	Monza	7	2	1	4	13	15	-2	7
15	Bologna	7	1	2	4	6	10	-4	5
16	Udinese	7	1	1	5	9	16	-7	4
17	Genoa	7	1	1	5	5	13	-8	4
18	Fiorentina	7	1	1	5	8	17	-9	4
19	Parma	7	1	1	5	4	13	-9	4
20	Venezia	7	1	0	6	6	16	-10	3

Spanish LaLiga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Barcelona	9	9	0	0	39	9	30	27
2	Atletico Madrid	9	7	1	1	19	8	11	22
3	Real Madrid	9	7	0	2	23	9	14	21
4	Real Betis	9	6	1	2	16	14	2	19
5	Real Sociedad	9	5	1	3	17	17	0	16
6	Sevilla	9	4	2	3	14	16	-2	14
7	Alaves	9	3	2	4	13	10	3	11
8	Celta Vigo	9	2	5	2	10	7	3	11
9	Deportivo	9	2	5	2	13	12	1	11
10	Osasuna	9	3	2	4	10	18	-8	11
11	Levante	9	2	4	3	15	17	-2	10
12	Villarreal	9	2	3	4	13	13	0	9
13	Athletic Club	8	2	3	3	8	9	-1	9
14	Rayo Vallecano	8	2	3	3	12	17	-5	9
15	Getafe	9	2	3	4	5	11	-6	9
16	Espanyol	9	2	2	5	11	12	-1	8
17	Racing Santander	9	2	2	5	13	25	-12	8
18	Elche	9	1	4	4	11	17	-6	7
19	Valencia	9	1	3	5	6	15	-9	6
20	Malaga	9	0	4	5	6	18	-12	4

German Bundesliga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Bayern	6	4	2	0	22	5	17	14
2	Dortmund	6	4	2	0	11	4	7	14
3	SC Freiburg	6	4	1	1	15	6	9	13
4	Leverkusen	6	4	1	1	16	9	7	13
5	Mainz	6	3	1	2	14	10	4	10
6	Elversberg	6	3	1	2	12	11	1	10
7	RB Leipzig	6	3	0	3	16	11	5	9
8	Werder	6	2	3	1	12	12	0	9
9	Hamburg	6	3	0	3	6	15	-9	9
10	FC Augsburg	6	2	2	2	16	12	4	8
11	E. Frankfurt	6	2	2	2	10	16	-6	8
12	Cologne	6	2	1	3	8	11	-3	7
13	Stuttgart	6	2	0	4	8	10	-2	6
14	Hoffenheim	6	2	0	4	11	14	-3	6
15	Schalke	6	1	2	3	4	7	-3	5
16	SC Paderborn	6	1	2	3	5	9	-4	5
17	Union Berlin	6	1	2	3	5	17	-12	5
18	M'gladbach	6	0	0	6	8	20	-12	0

Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	861	898
2	Steve Smith	822	947
3	Joe Root	816	932
4	Travis Head	778	884
5	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
6	Temba Bavuma	735	806
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Aiden Markram	706	759

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	865	872
2	Matt Henry	861	870
3	Ollie Robinson	856	856
4	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
5	Pat Cummins	846	914
6	Marco Jansen	831	831
7	Josh Hazlewood	818	864
8	Kagiso Rabada	799	902
9	Scott Boland	796	820
10	Noman Ali	777	853

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	841	855
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	781	908
4	Rohit Sharma	770	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Shai Hope	710	782
7	Babar Azam	689	894
8	Kusal Mendis	674	675
9	Joe Root	660	810
10	K.L. Rahul	653	676

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	742	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	662	675
3	Keshav Maharaj	660	737
4	Mitchell Santner	644	656
5	Kuldeep Yadav	620	757
6	Maheesh Theekshana	616	680
7	Jofra Archer	611	682
8	Shaheen Afridi	601	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	596	722
10	Jayden Seales	591	591

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	893	916
2	Abhishek Sharma	884	931
3	Sahibzada Farhan	883	883
4	Shreyas Iyer	798	829
5	Harry Brook	793	793
6	Jos Buttler	789	794
6	Dewald Brevis	789	806
8	Phil Salt	775	881
9	Shai Hope	759	766
10	Tilak Varma	726	745

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	720	828
2	Adam Zampa	700	746
3	Adil Rashid	695	747
3	Abrar Ahmed	695	757
5	Nathan Ellis	675	678
6	Jamie Overton	674	674
7	Nasum Ahmed	661	661
8	Mahedi Hasan	654	654
9	Liam Dawson	648	652
10	Axar Patel	646	667

Hitting hard came naturally to me; but today, I wouldn't be in the top 100

Saurabh Tiwary made the journey from under-19 champion to cricket administrator in less than two decades. Along the way, he had his moments in the IPL, represented India and excelled at the domestic level. He speaks in this interview about the benefits of ex-cricketers running the game, the evolution of the IPL and his memories of playing with Kohli and Tendulkar

INTERVIEW

Saurabh Tiwary

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Saurabh Tiwary was often compared to M.S. Dhoni, as much for his big hitting as his long mane. The left-hander was a part of the Virat Kohli-led Indian team that won the Under-19 World Cup in 2008. He promised a lot, but played only three ODIs. He also has a stellar First Class record (8,076 runs, average of 47.22, 22 hundreds and 34 fifties). Tiwary now heads the Jharkhand State Cricket Association. Excerpts from an interview he gave *The Hindu* at Jamshedpur:

What made you take up cricket administration?

Some members of the JSCA approached me and said that I should fight the election. I said, 'Okay, I will fight.'

You won the election quite comfortably.

Yes, and I am grateful to all the members who have supported me. I decided to contest because I wanted to do something for the players. And as a player, I know what they need. When you have played cricket for 24 years, you know that. I have been trying to help the Jharkhand players since I took over as the JSCA secretary last year.

I believe a cricket association is there because of cricketers, and not the other way around. I ensure our players are given all the opportunities. Since facilities are less in Jharkhand, our players, male or female, are free to use the Ranchi stadium whenever they want.

I have won the Vijay Hazare Trophy, but never the Ranji Trophy or the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. I want Jharkhand to win those tournaments. People often ask – What is the difference between a sportsperson and an administrator? The only difference is that a player can understand their emotions, because he has gone through that experience.

One of our players, Rajandeep Singh, is not fit, but he has been coming to our Ranchi stadium for the last three months. We have never abandoned any of the players who are injured. We have given them treatment.

So you would like more former cricketers to come into administration?

I think that when any player who has played for his State comes into administration, he will know how he can help his team develop.

In your time, there weren't many hard-hitting batters like you.

Hitting hard came naturally to me. I liked to bat that way. But if I were to play today, I wouldn't be in the top 100. Every second batsman is hitting so well. Even a 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is dominating in the IPL. We didn't have that much T20 cricket back then. Then scores like 140 or 150 used to be defended. Now even 250 cannot be defended. Power-hitting has taken over.

> There are some memories that you have in cricket for a lifetime. One of them is batting with Sachin Tendulkar

> Today's boys are all very strong. They hit continuously and do not get tired

Do you see any change in technique?

It is all the mindset. People have played so much T20 cricket, they know they can come back into a match. Sometimes I see the score in an IPL match after 10 overs is 70 for five. If you switch off the TV and move a little here and there, and you turn the TV on again, you will see the score is 210 for seven.

Today's cricket has almost become a game of power-hitting. They hit continuously and do not get tired. In ODIs, you see teams chasing down scores like 370. And batters are hitting double hundreds inside 43 overs.

Today's boys are all very strong. The kind of training they do at gyms is also a factor. If you want to become strong, then you have to do weight-training.

You played for more than a decade in the IPL right from its inaugural edition in 2008. How much has it changed over the years?

Now it is very difficult to predict which team would be good. Earlier, every year one or two new players would emerge from the IPL. Now I think every year two or three players emerge from a team. Now India has such good bench strength because of the IPL. If you perform well there, you are in the limelight. You can play for India. If you play for five or six years in the IPL, you have financial security. Your life becomes better. There are a lot of players who have not played for India, but you still know their names. The IPL is the reason for that. When I started playing in the IPL, I did not imagine it would become this big. The full credit goes to the BCCI.

You were the emerging player of 2010. You scored an unbeaten 52 off 31 balls to help Mumbai Indians beat Royal Challengers Bangalore (as it was known then) in the semifinal.

I also remember playing a crucial innings [38 not out] against RCB in the Champions League T20 in South Africa that year. There are some memories that you have in cricket for a lifetime. One of them is batting with Sachin Tendulkar. It was my dream to play with him.

You were part of an Indian team that won the Under-19 World Cup in Malaysia. Your teammates included Virat Kohli, Ravindra Jadeja and Abhinav Mukund...

Winning that World Cup was a dream come true for me. If you win anything for India, it is a big achievement. All those things, and memories ... they will be with you as long as you live.

It was fun. If you look at the whole batch, many players went on to play for India [the senior team].

Did you imagine at the time that Kohli would develop into the cricketer and the leader he became?

I am not at all surprised. He played with the kind of hunger that we still see today. He plays his cricket with so much passion and honesty. As for his leadership quality, it was the first time that he became the captain. But there was no doubt about his dedication and focus.

How do you look back at the final against South Africa?

Please don't remind me of it. I got run out. I will never forget that. But overall, that World Cup was a very good experience.

Your international career didn't last long...

When I was playing, it was already a packed Indian team. I remember I used to come to the team when someone got injured. It was very difficult to get into the team. But at the same time, I didn't perform that well. And I didn't perform that well in the IPL after 2010. But I have no regrets. Cricket has given me everything. Sometimes I even wonder if I deserve all this. Everything is cricket for me. Today, I am talking to you because of cricket.

PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK



PHOTO: K. BHAGYA PRAKASH





PHOTO: P.K. AJITH KUMAR

GAME THEORY

Relentless excellence at the wheel

With back-to-back wins in Malaysia and Singapore, Max Verstappen extended his streak of Formula One seasons with a race victory to 11. This is also the longest ongoing unbroken string of campaigns with at least one finish on the podium's top step. How does the four-time World champion stack up against the giants of the sport in this regard?

MOST CONSECUTIVE SEASONS WITH AT LEAST ONE WIN

Driver	Seasons	Total
Michael Schumacher	1992–2006	15
Lewis Hamilton	2007–2021	15
Max Verstappen	2016–2026 (ongoing)	11
Alain Prost	1981–1990	10
Ayrton Senna	1985–1993	9
Nelson Piquet	1980–1987	8
Stirling Moss	1955–1961	7
Jim Clark	1962–1968	7
David Coulthard	1997–2003	7
Jackie Stewart	1968–1973	6
Sebastian Vettel	2008–2013	6











SOURCE: F1

PICTURE THIS



GETTY IMAGES

Sunlit run

An athlete competes in the run portion of the Ironman World championship earlier this month in Kailua Kona, Hawaii.

The Ironman triathlon, which comprises a 3.9-km swim, a 180.2-km bicycle ride and a 42.2-km marathon, is widely considered one of the most arduous one-day competitions in all of sport.

The Ironman World championship was the original Ironman triathlon, and it has been held annually in Hawaii since 1978. First staged in O'ahu, it moved to Kailua-Kona in 1981.

The event is popular enough to merit television coverage in multiple continents.

"Swim in the turquoise waters of Kailua Bay, bike across the raw, volcanic landscapes of the Queen Ka'ahumanu Highway, and run under the radiant Hawaiian sun toward the finish line on Ali'i Drive," says the race's official website, painting an alluring picture.

But while the setting is gorgeous, the athletes — tested to breaking point by the harsh conditions — are more concerned with surviving the race than taking in the sights. The course record was set in 2024 by Patrick Lange (7 hrs, 35 min, 53 sec).